



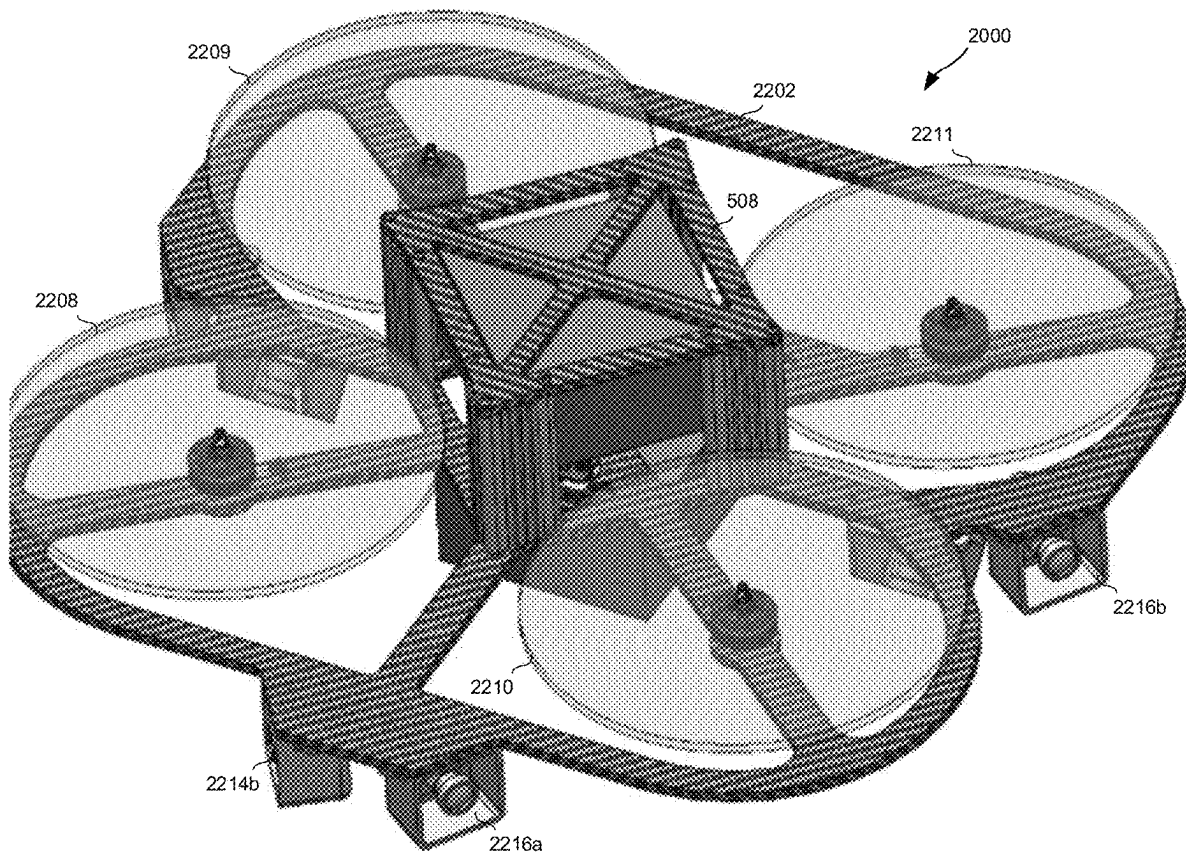
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Restifo et al.(10) **Pub. No.: US 2020/0301427 A1**(43) **Pub. Date: Sep. 24, 2020**(54) **MODULAR AUTONOMOUS DRONE**(71) Applicant: **DRONE RACING LEAGUE, INC.**,
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(57)

ABSTRACT

An autonomous quadcopter has four motors, each motor coupled to a corresponding propeller and a flight controller coupled to the four motors to provide input to the four motors to control flight. The autonomous quadcopter also has a plurality of cameras and an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to the plurality of cameras to receive input from the plurality of cameras, determine a flightpath for the autonomous quadcopter according to the input from the plurality of cameras, and provide commands to the flight controller to direct the flight controller to follow the flight-path.



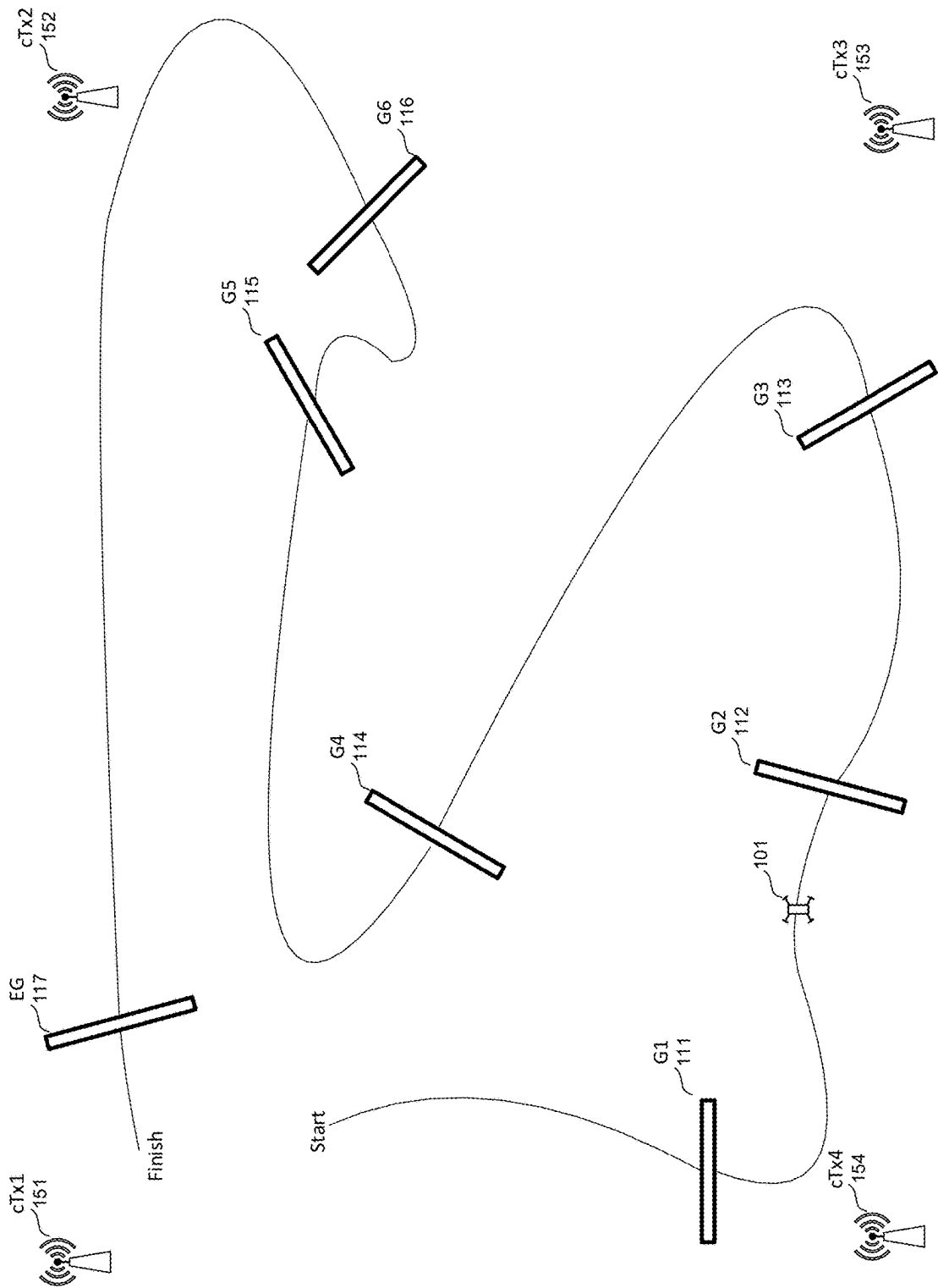


Figure 1

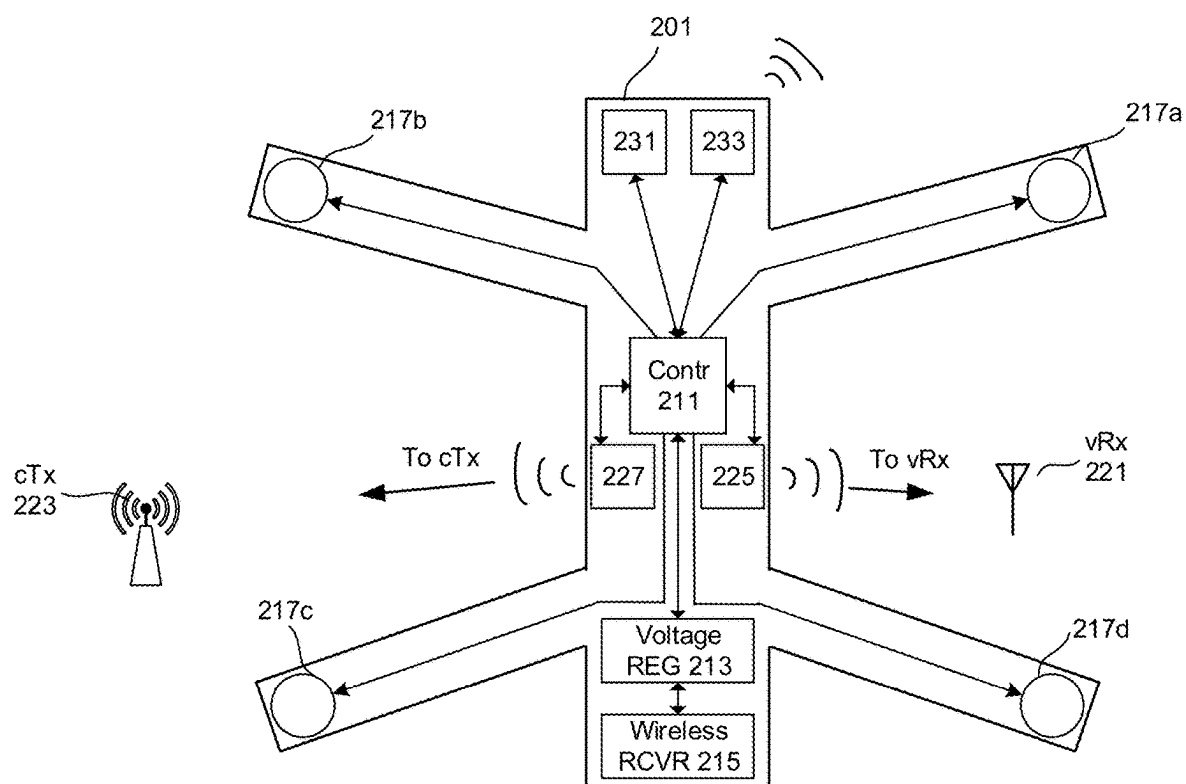


Figure 2

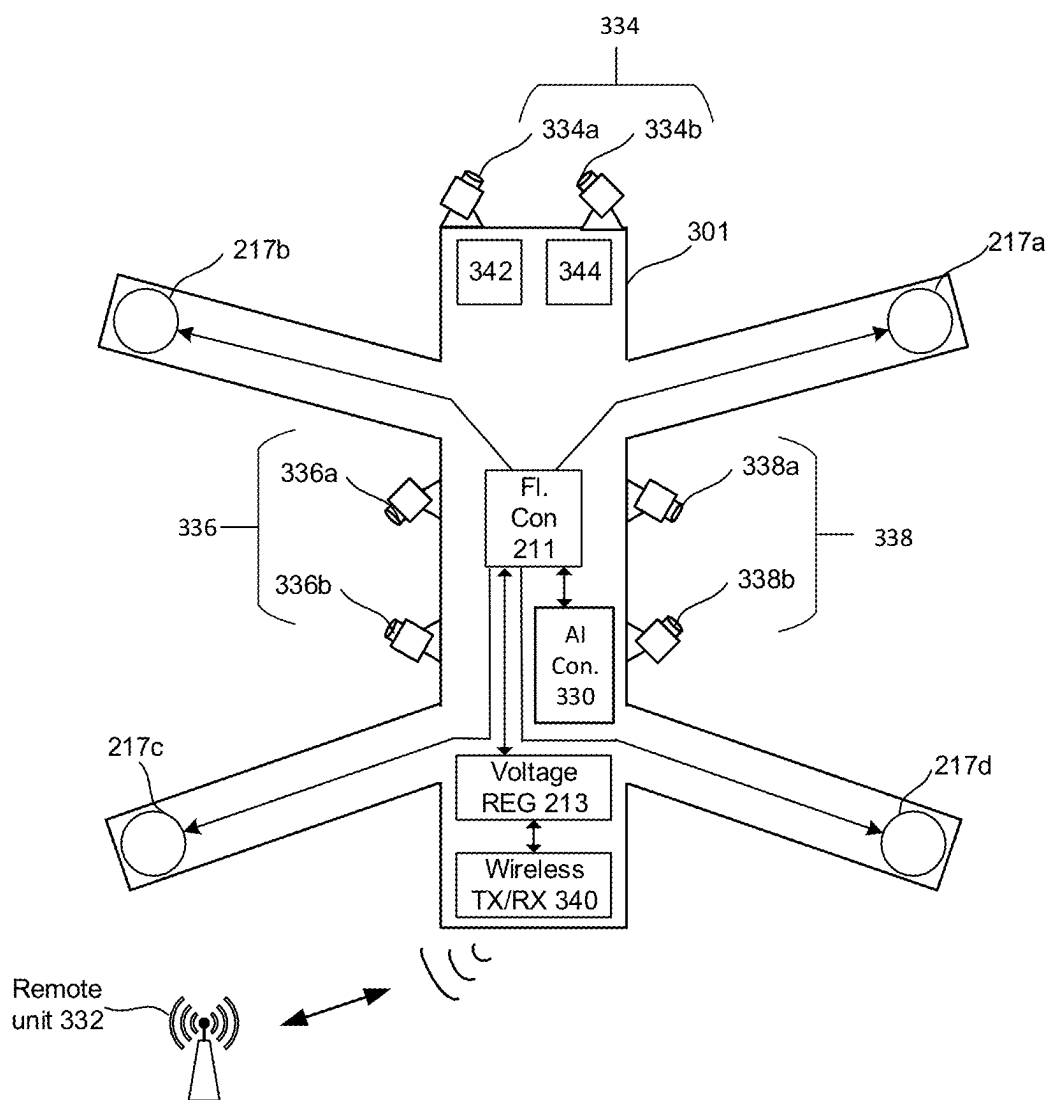


Figure 3

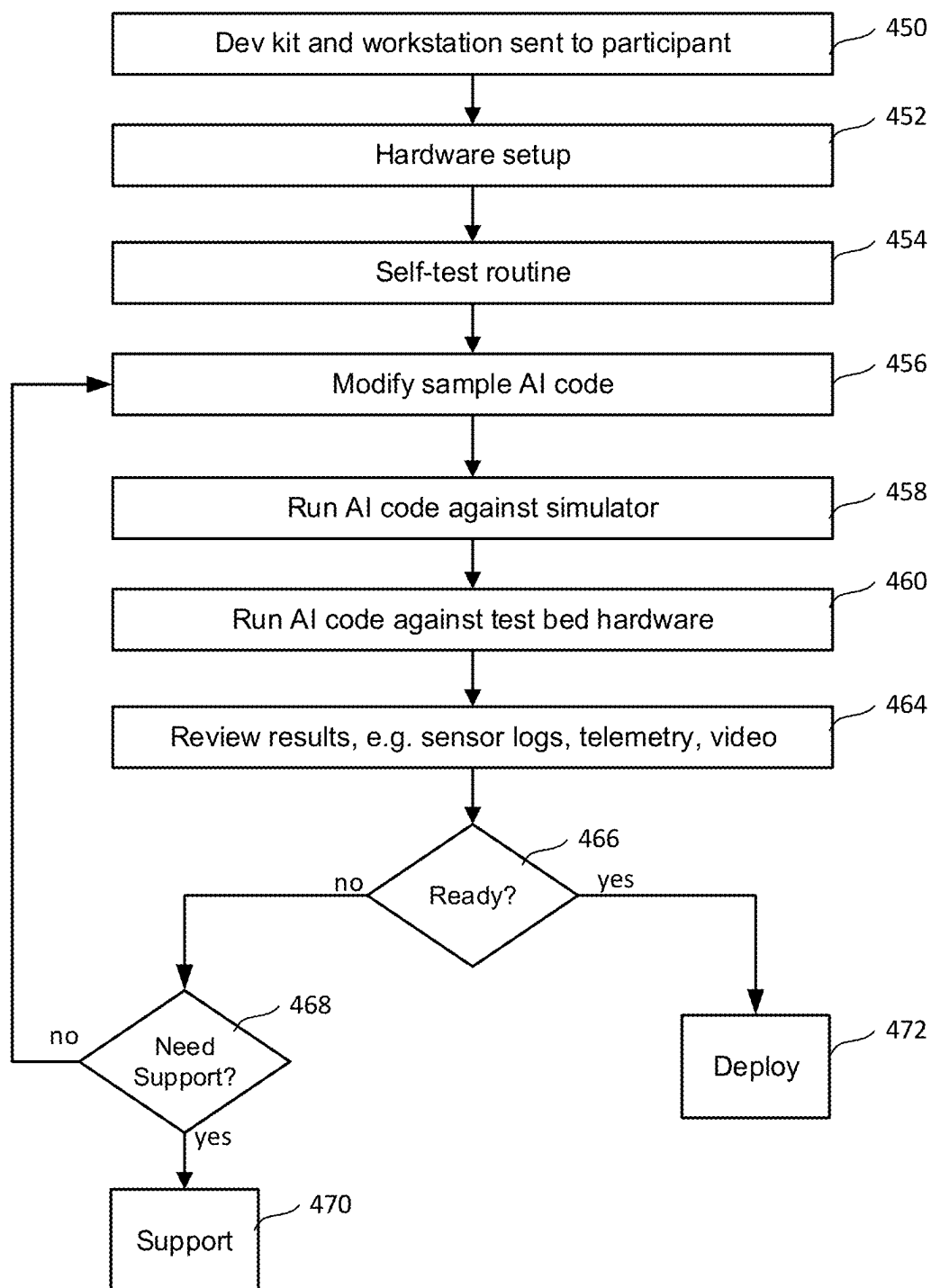


Figure 4

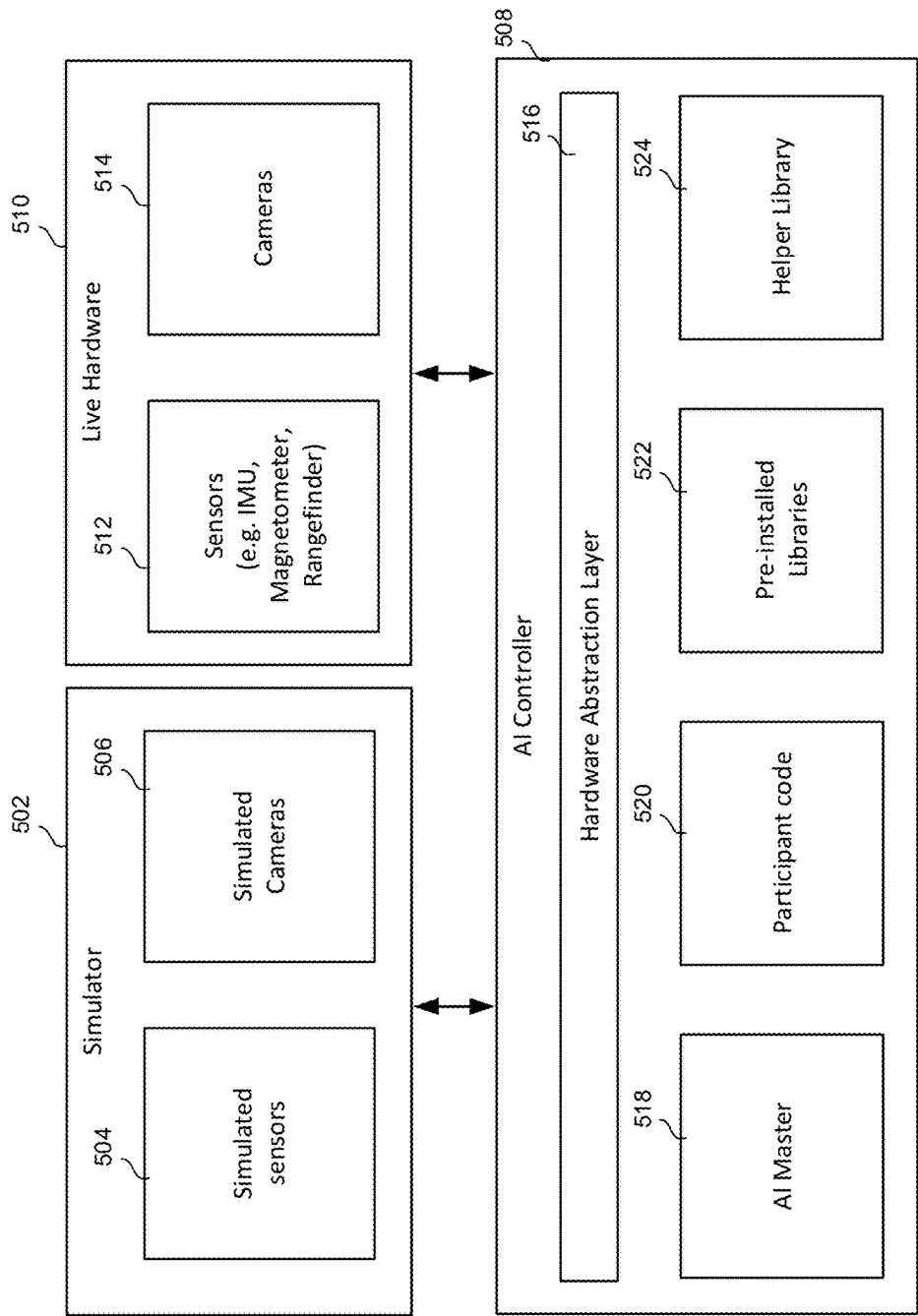


Figure 5

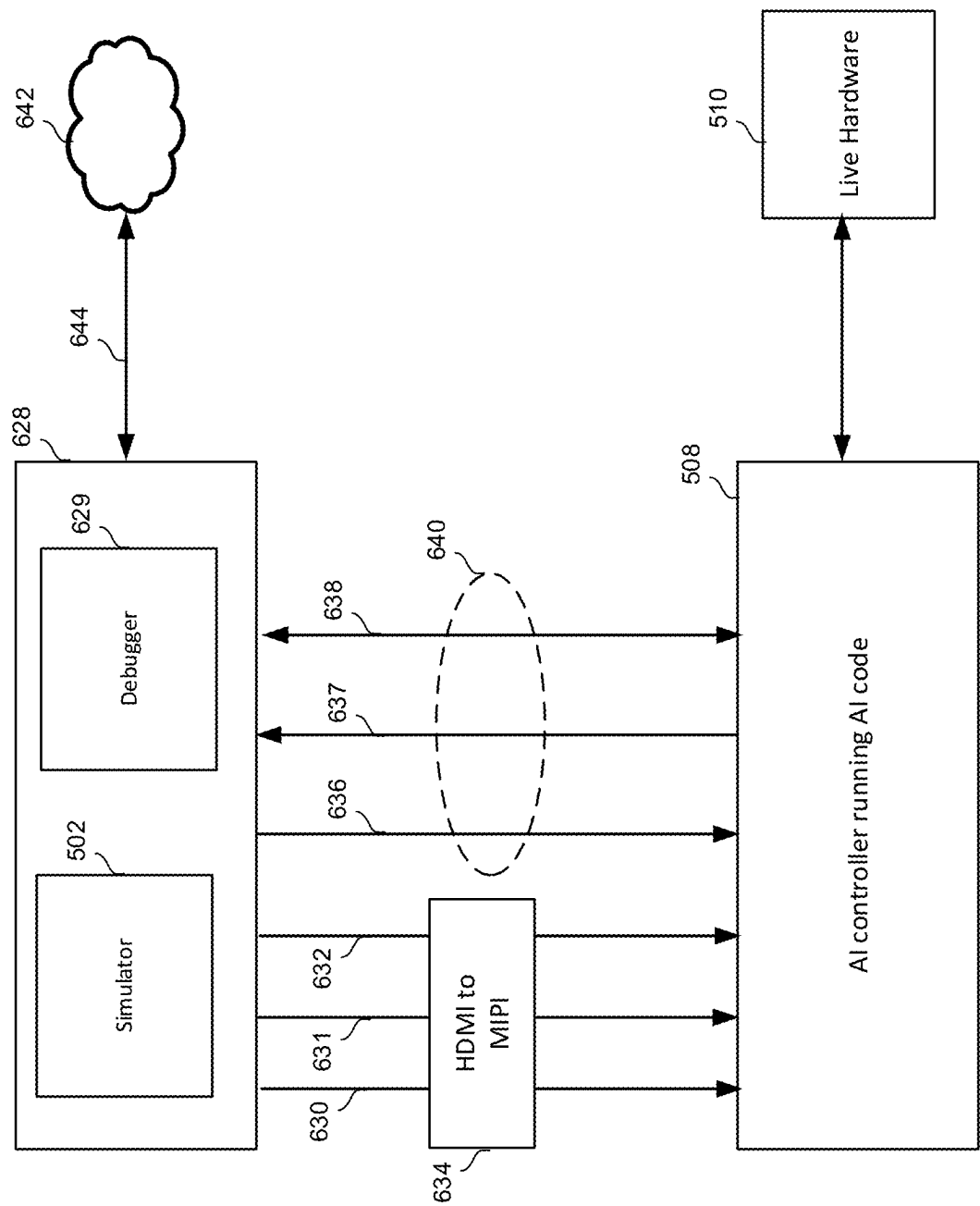


Figure 6A

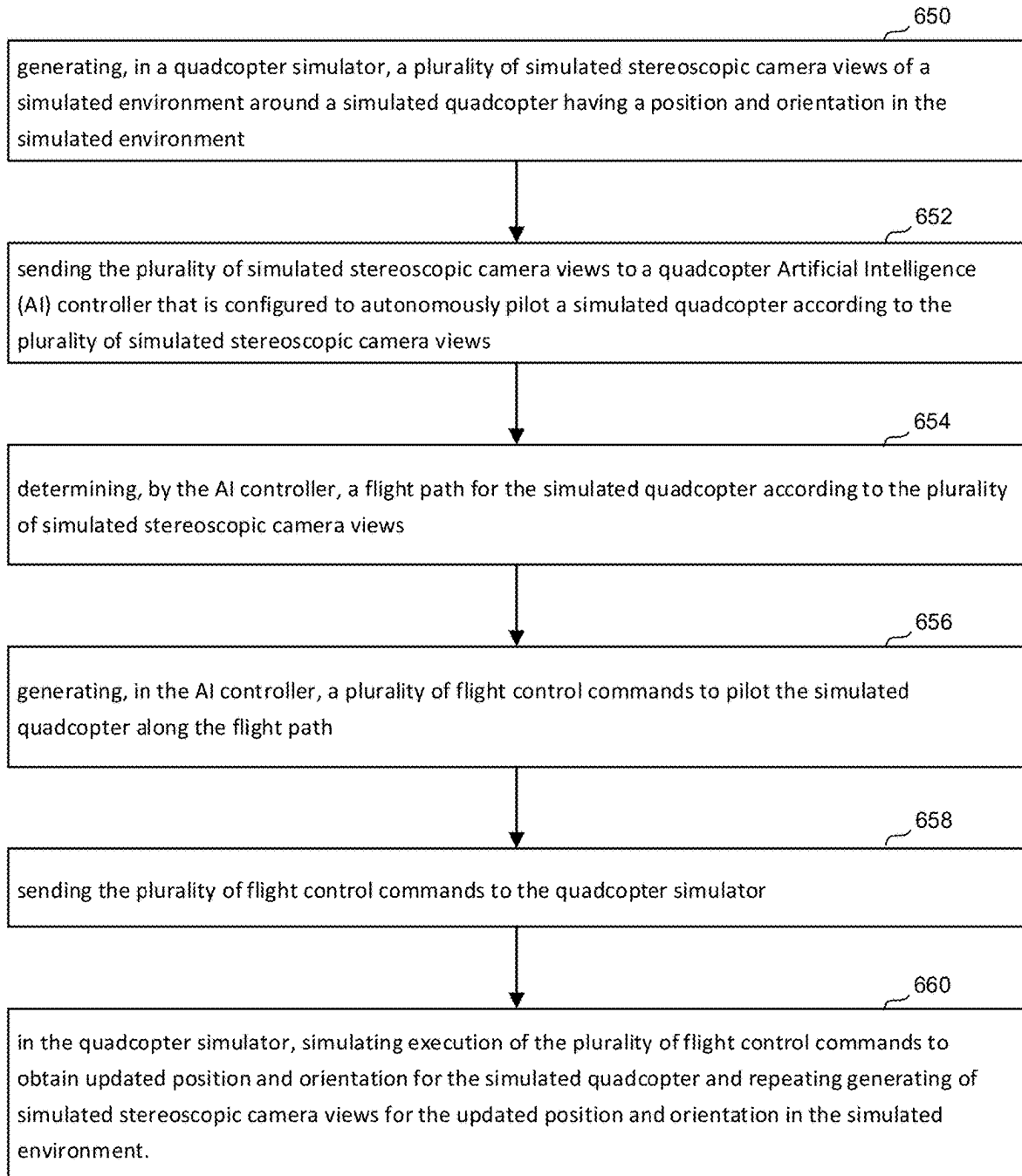


Figure 6B

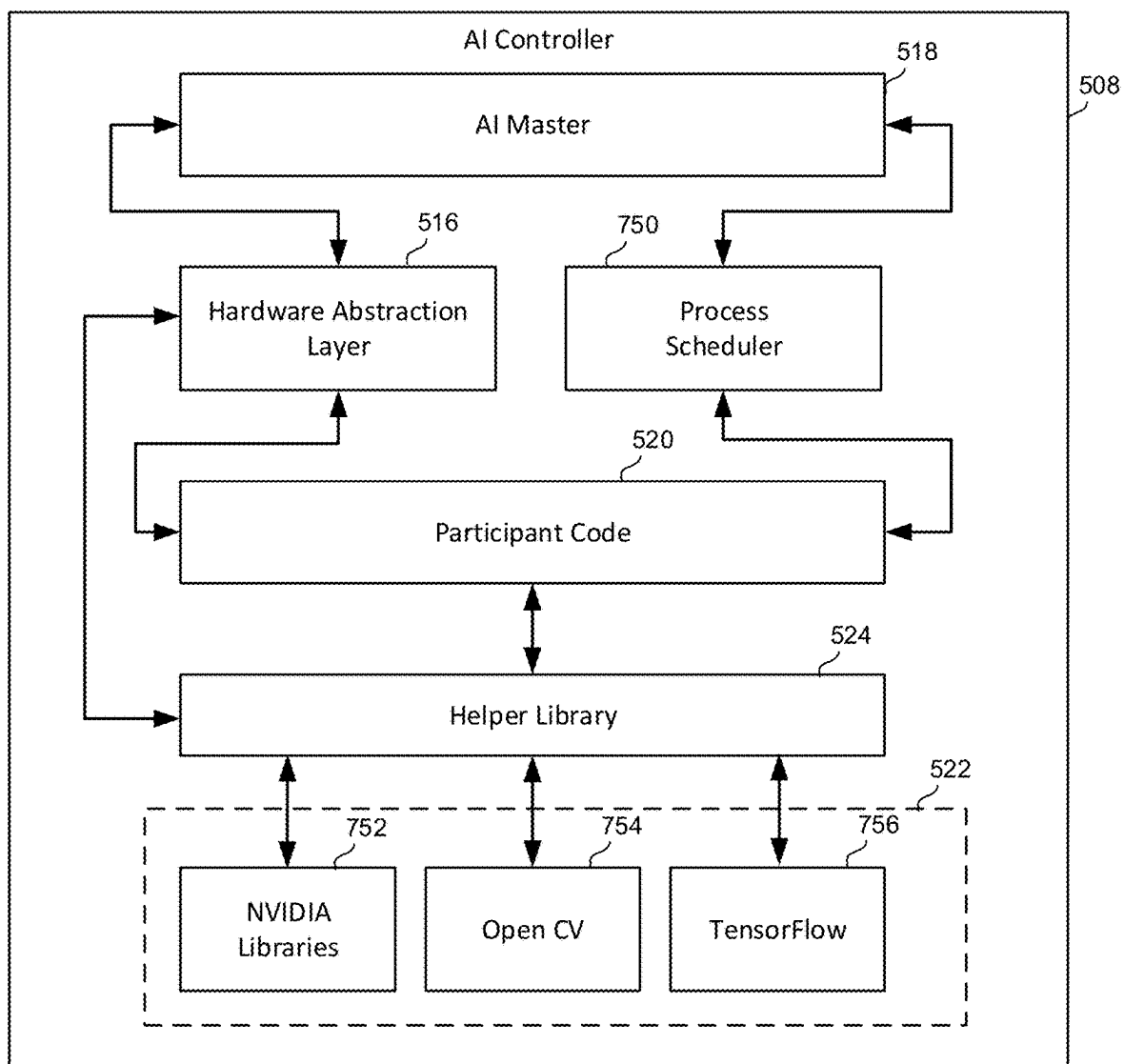


Figure 7

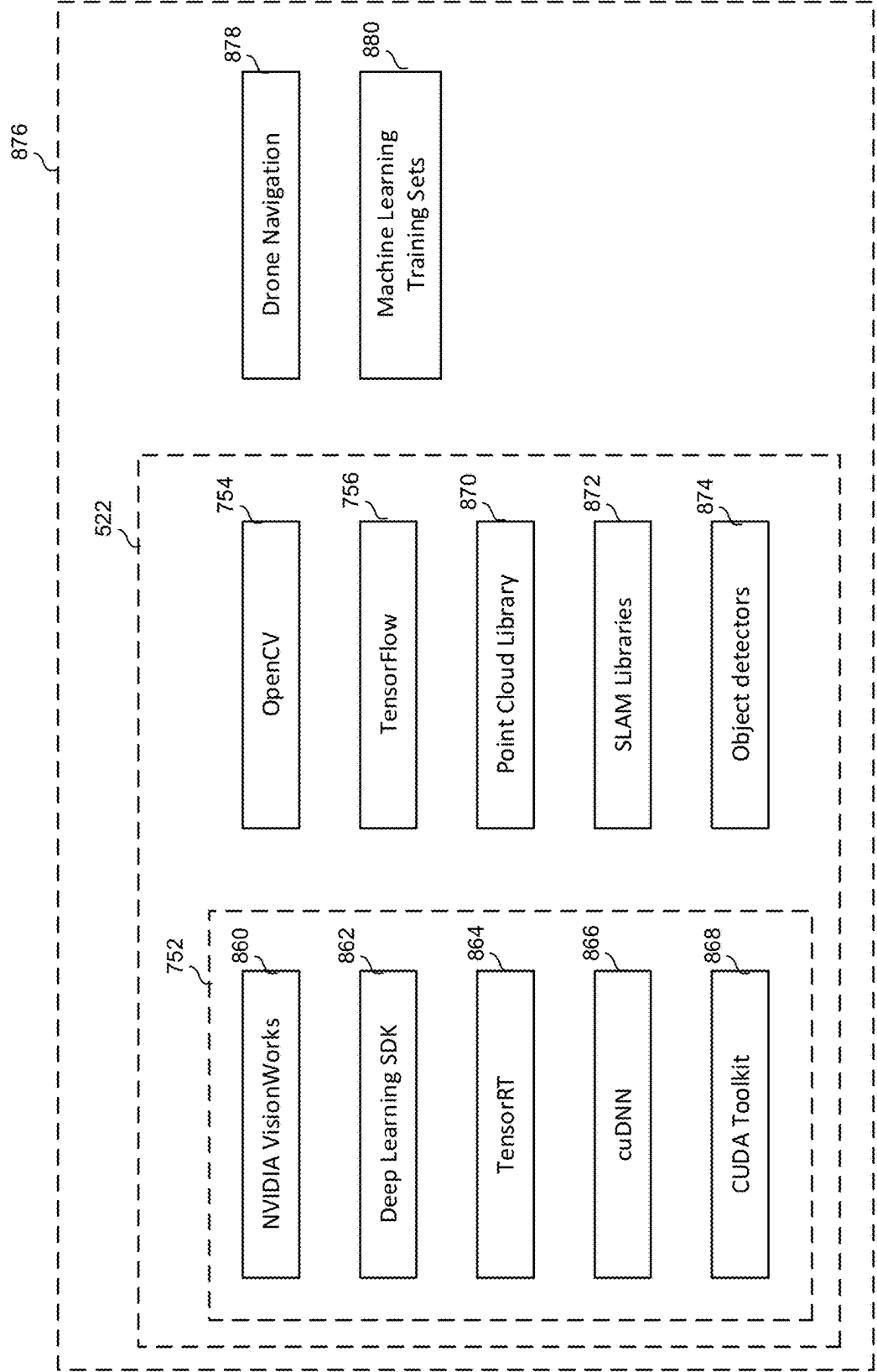


Figure 8

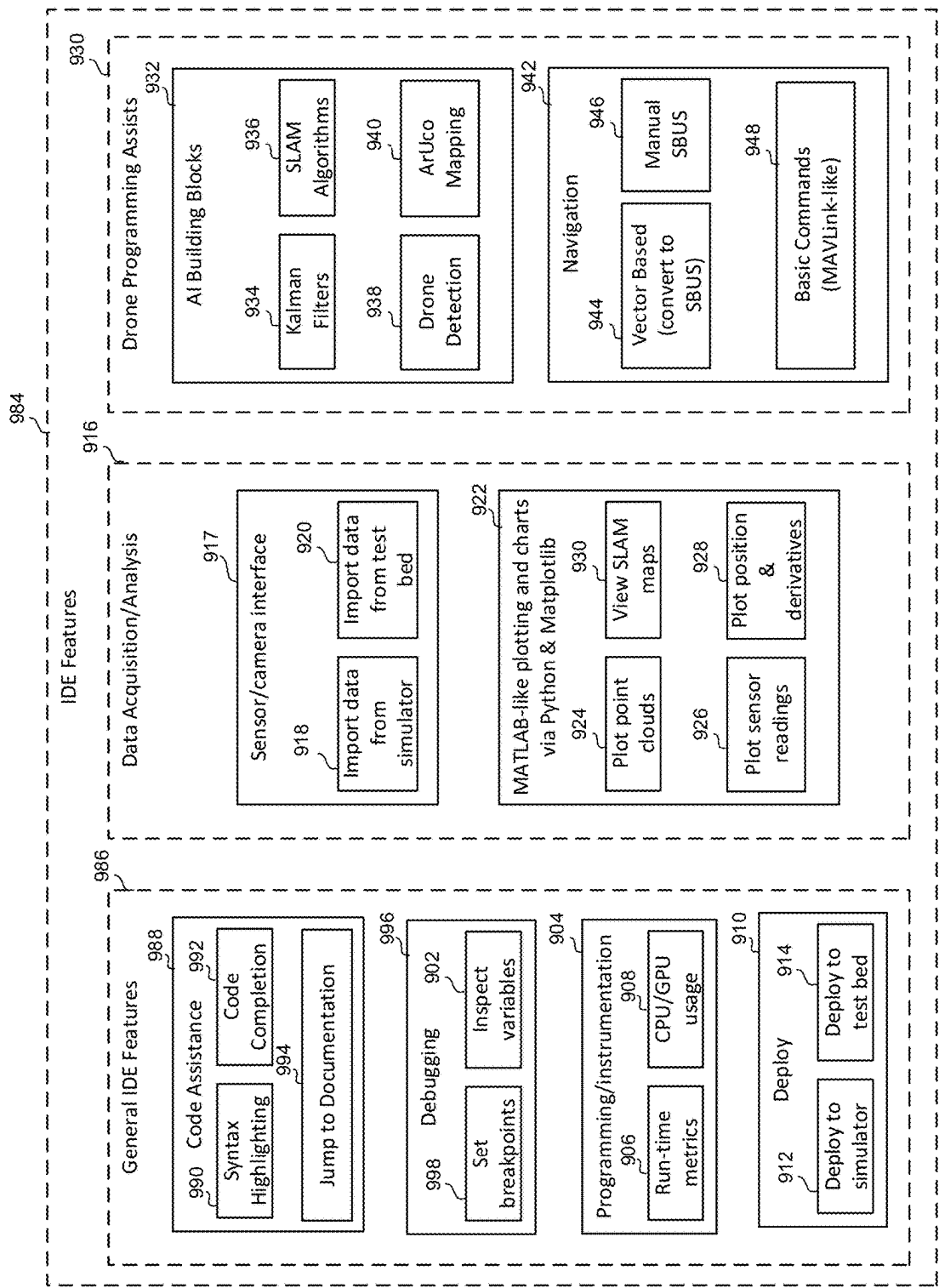


Figure 9

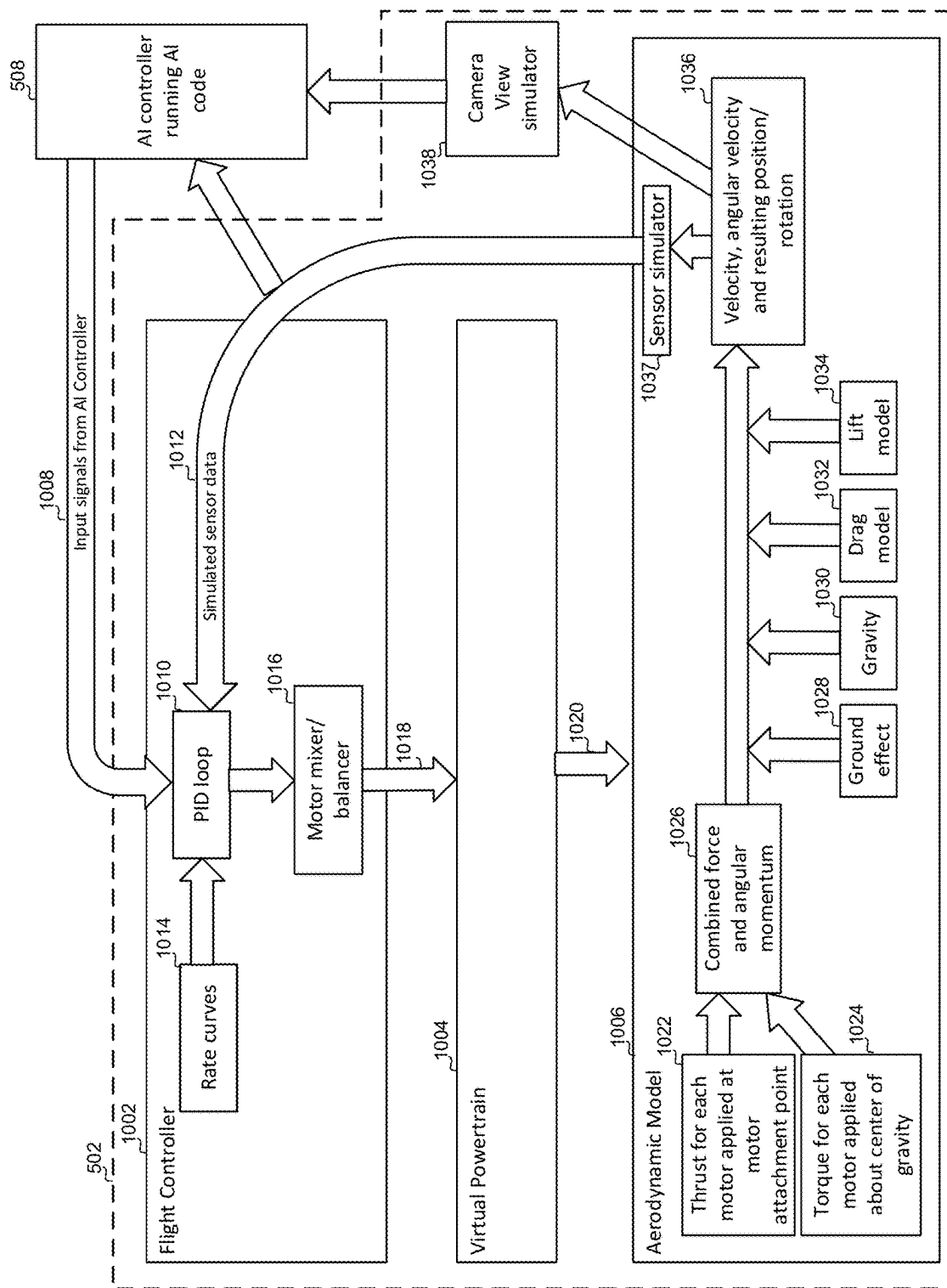


Figure 10A

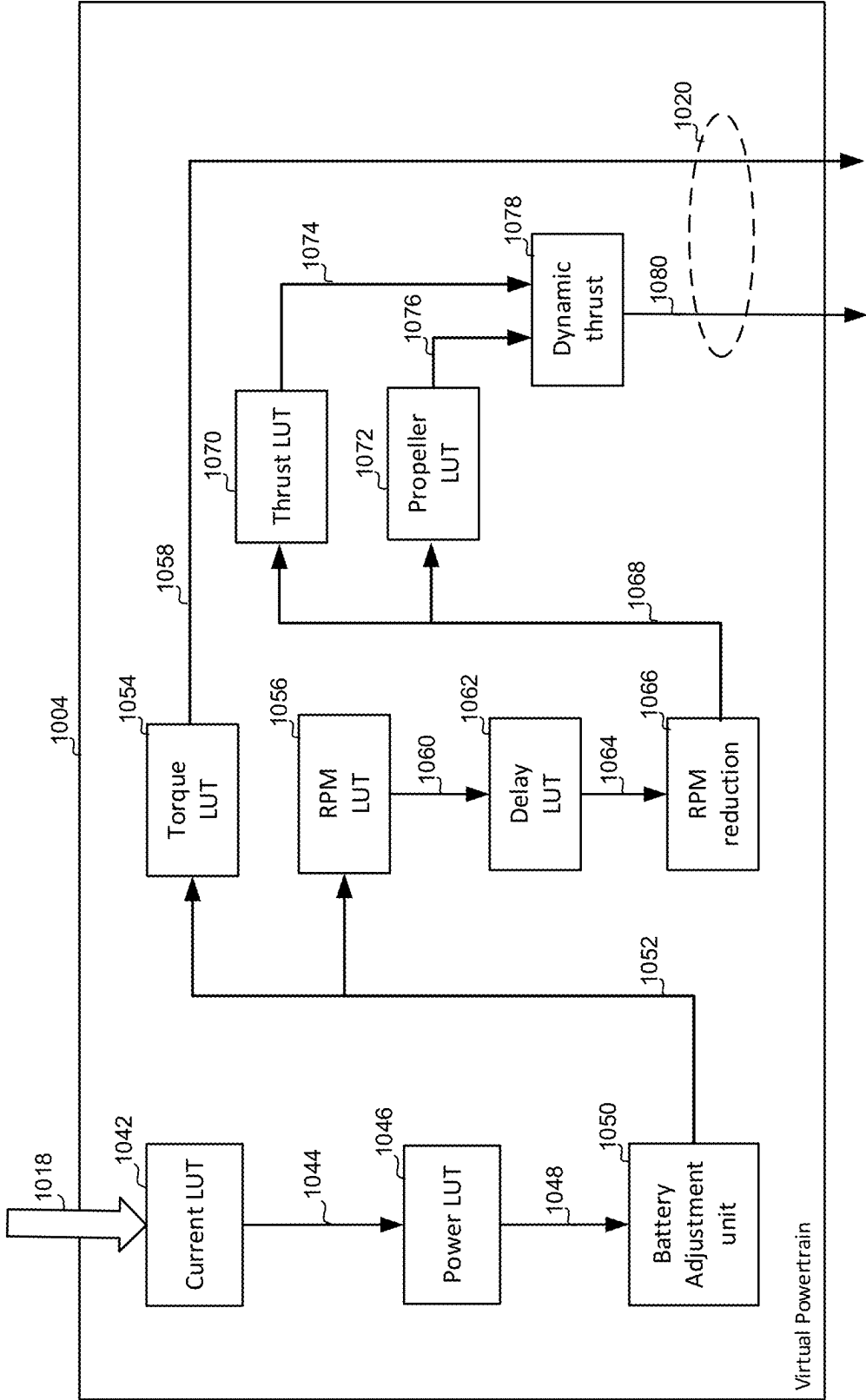


Figure 10B

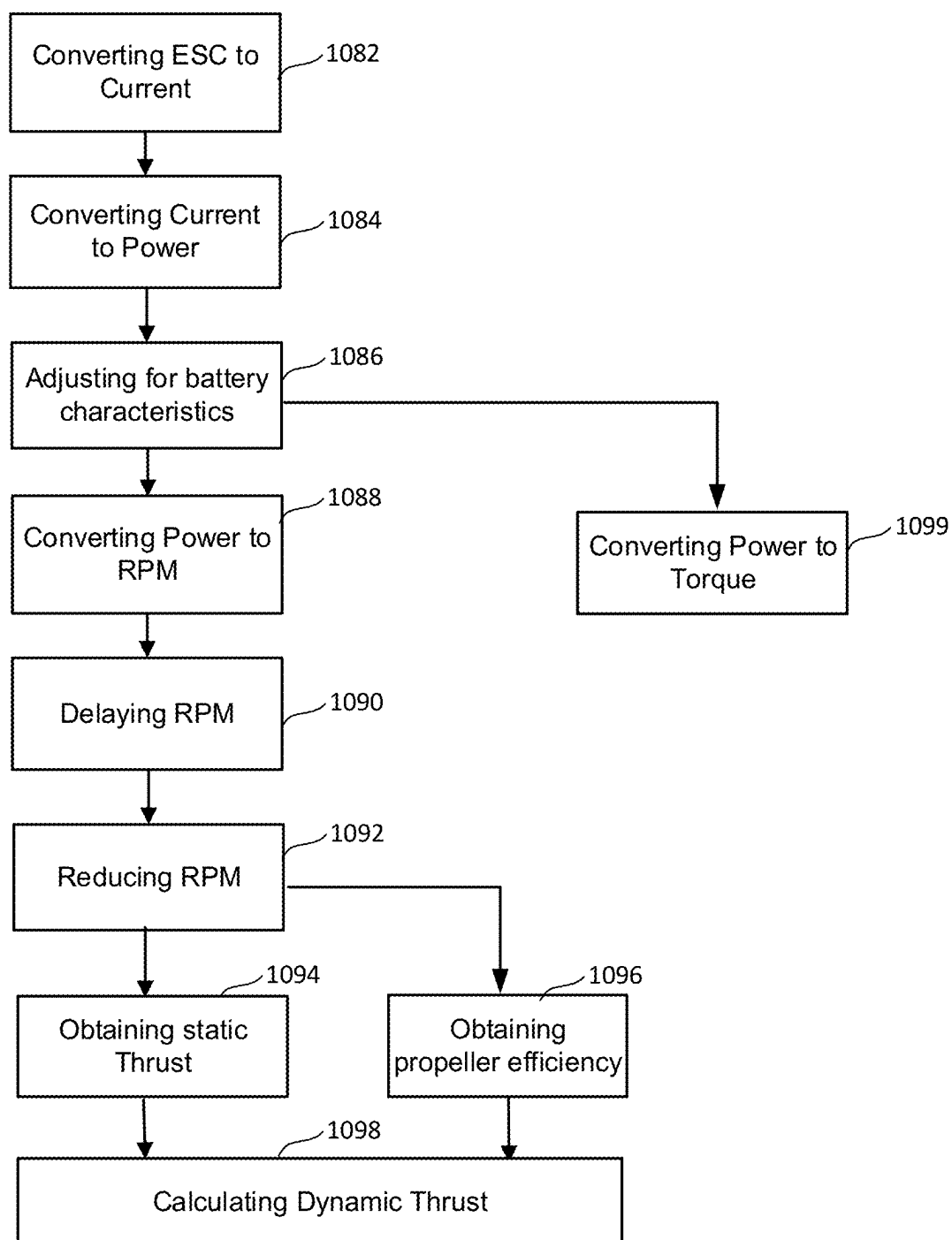


Figure 10C

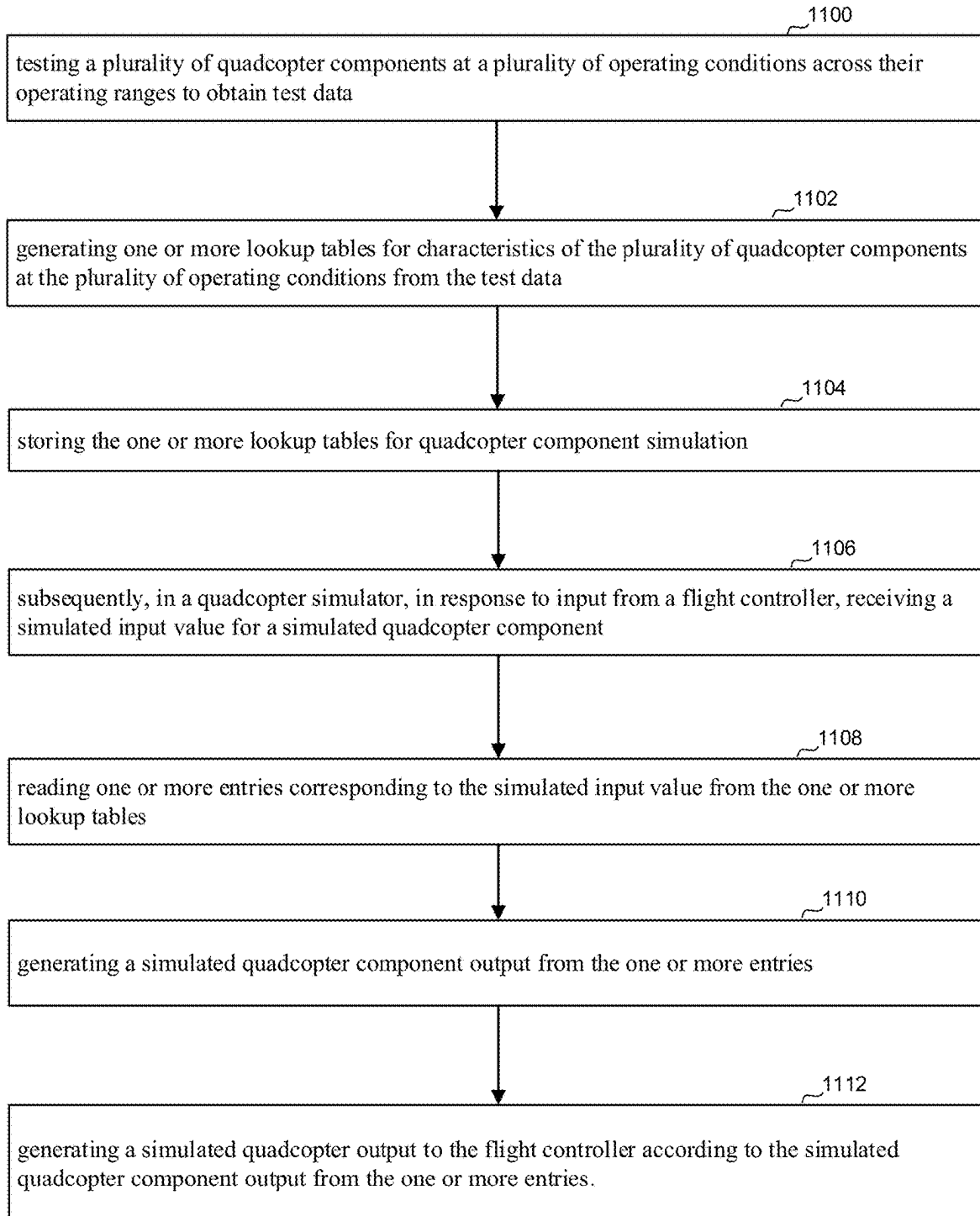


Figure 11

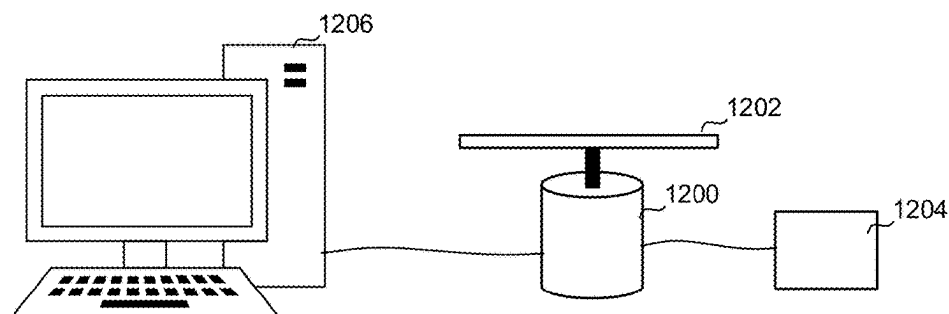


Figure 12

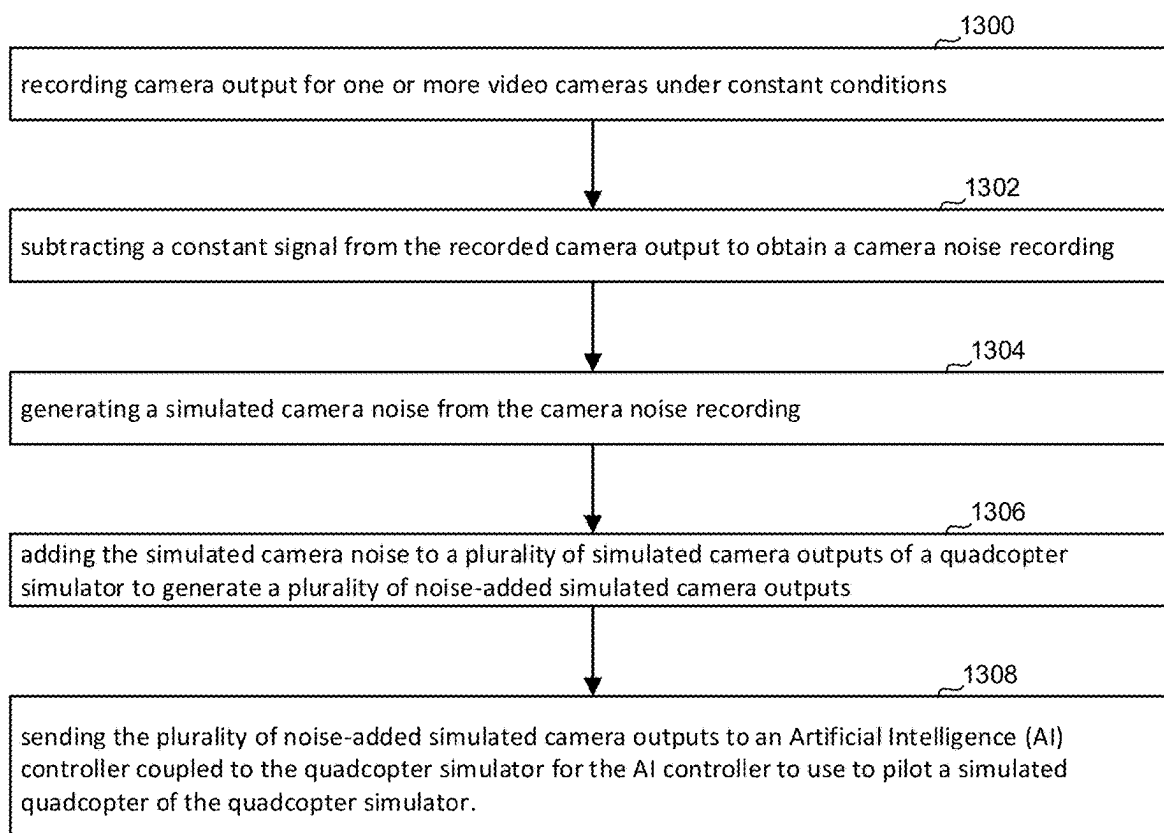


Figure 13

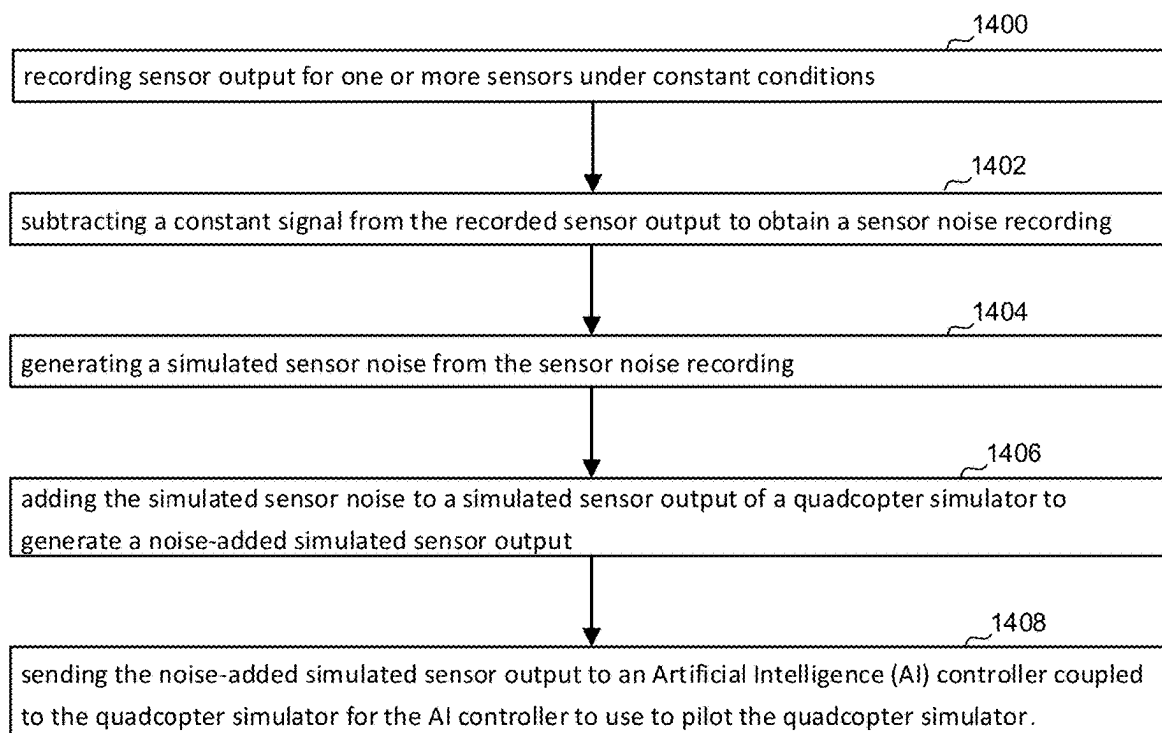


Figure 14

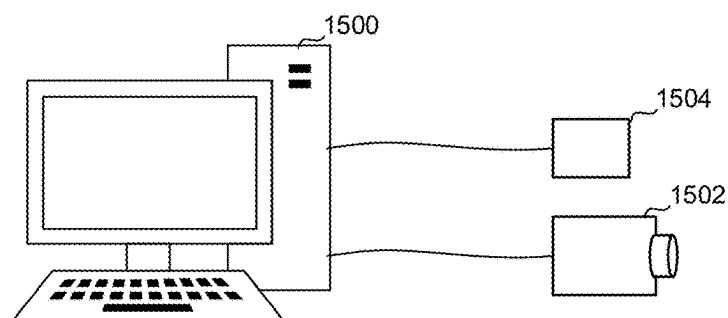


Figure 15

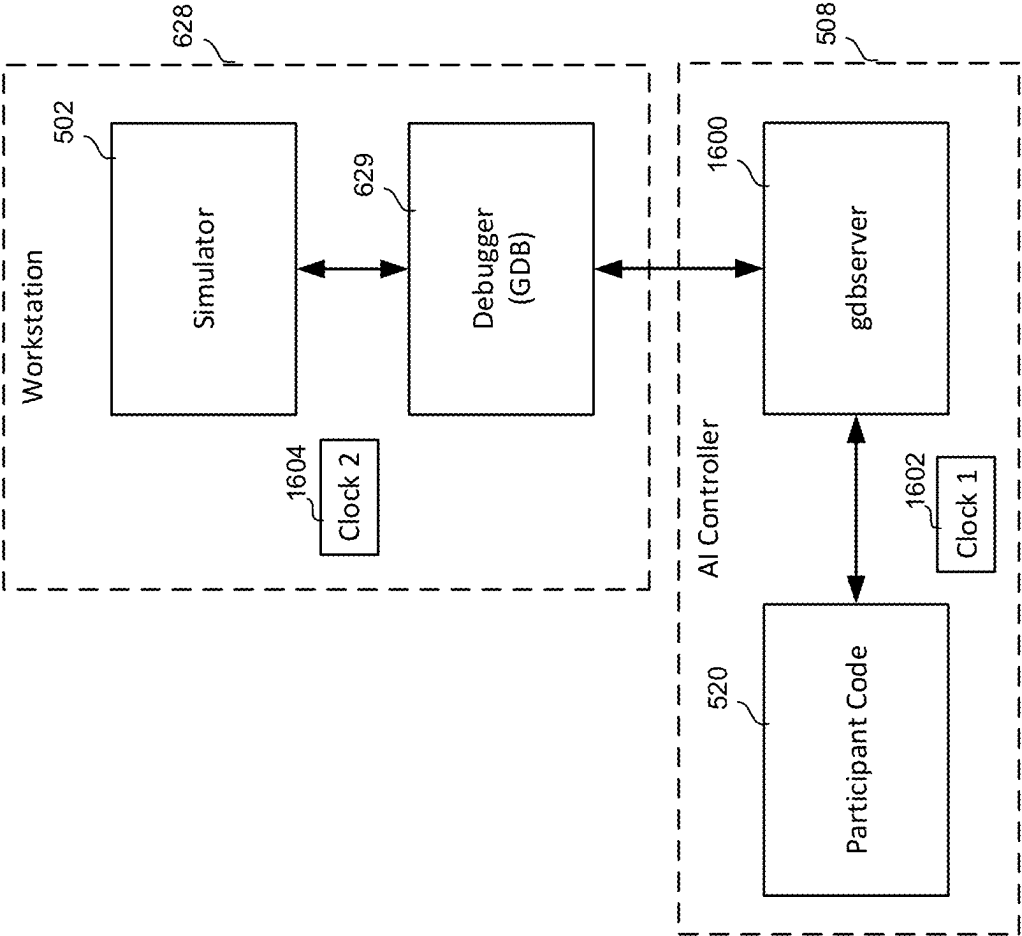


Figure 16

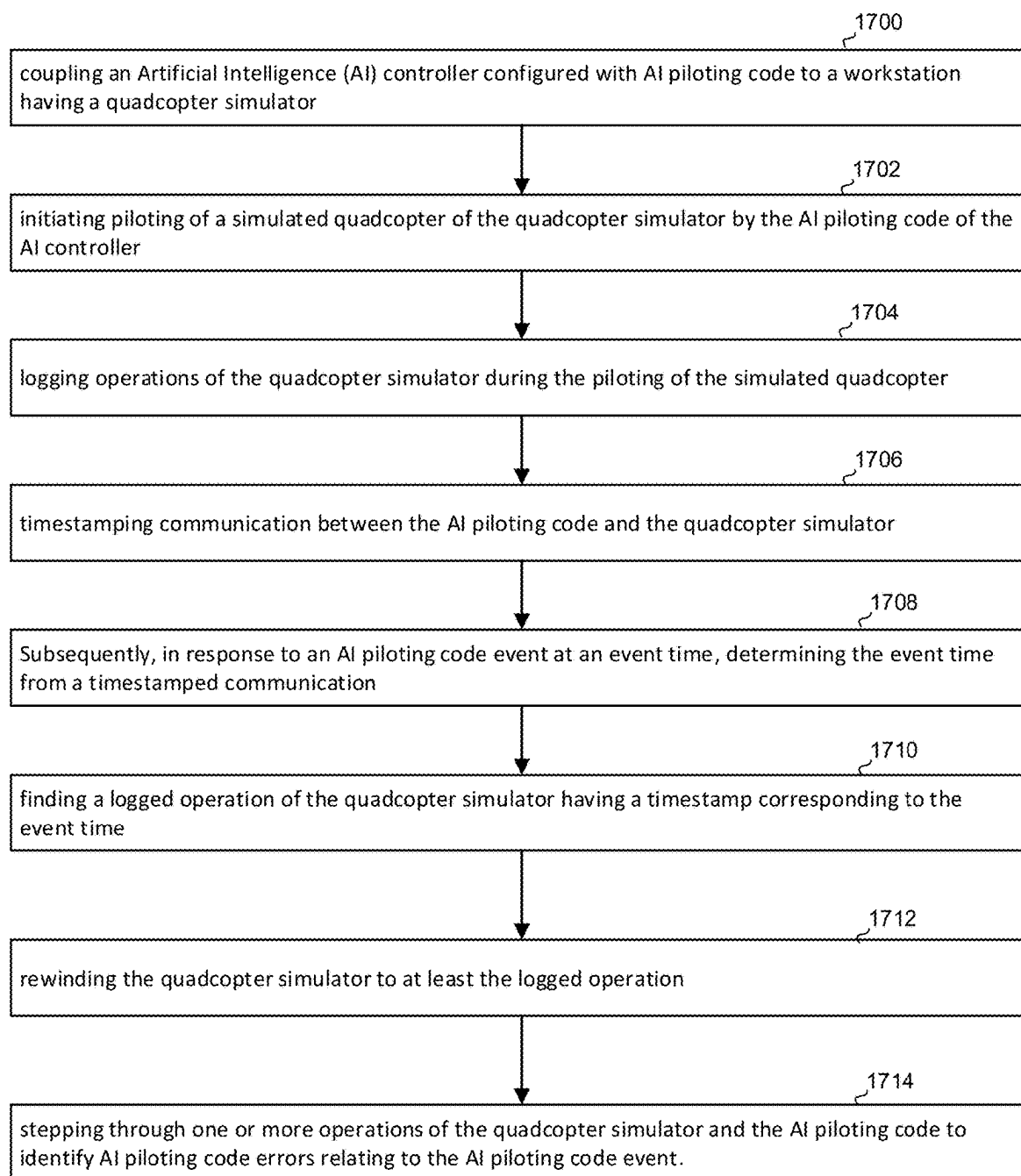


Figure 17

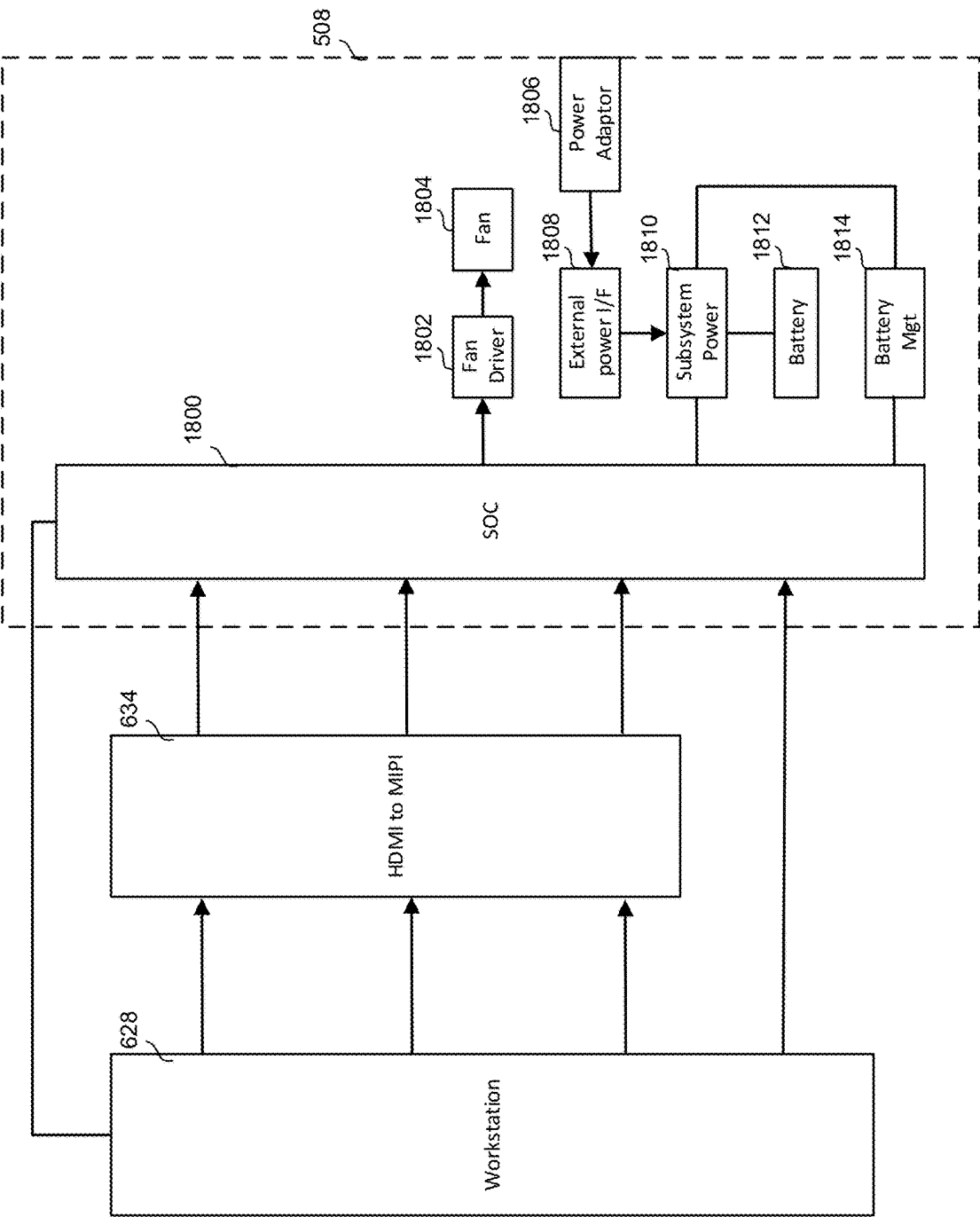


Figure 18

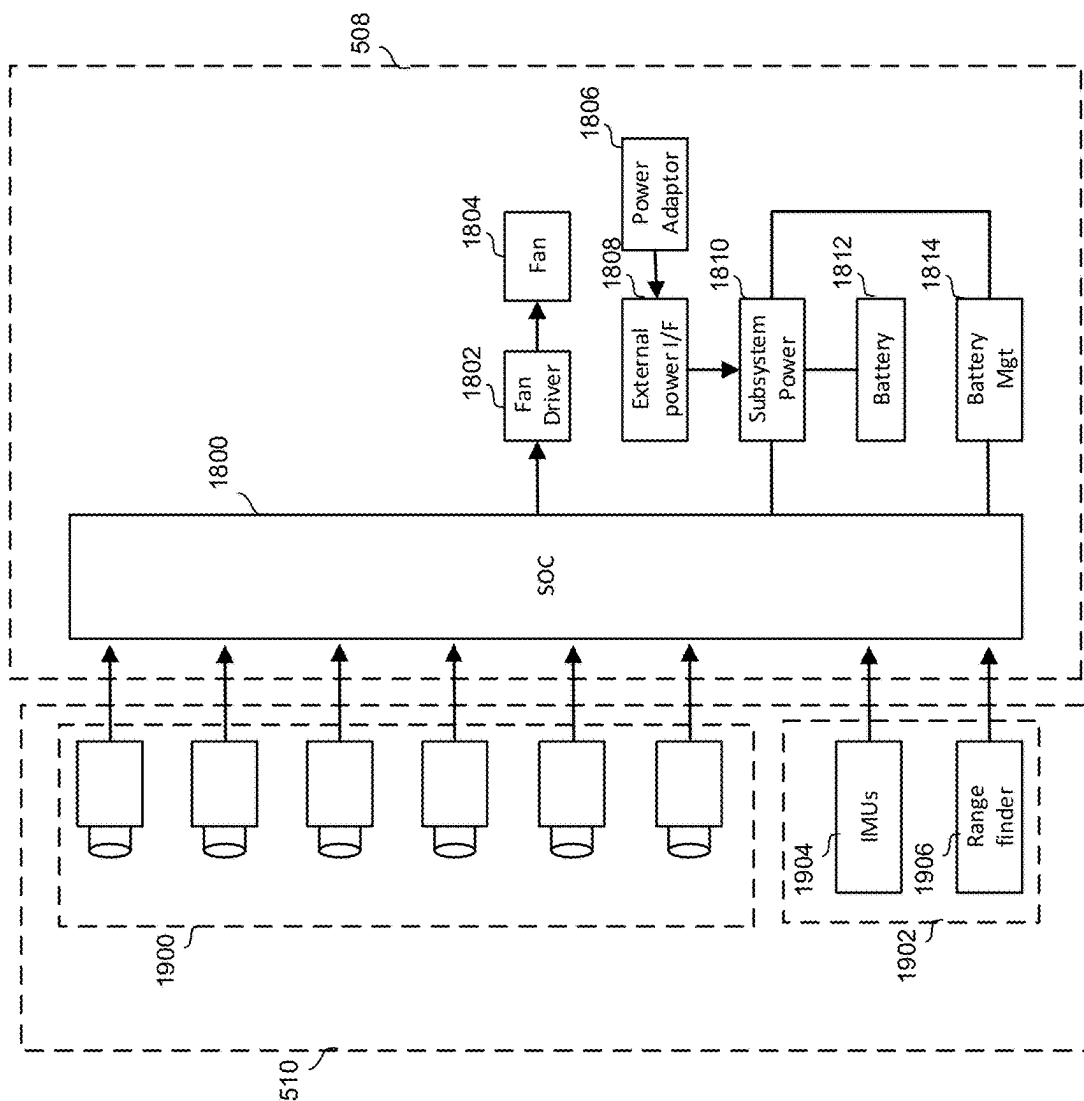


Figure 19

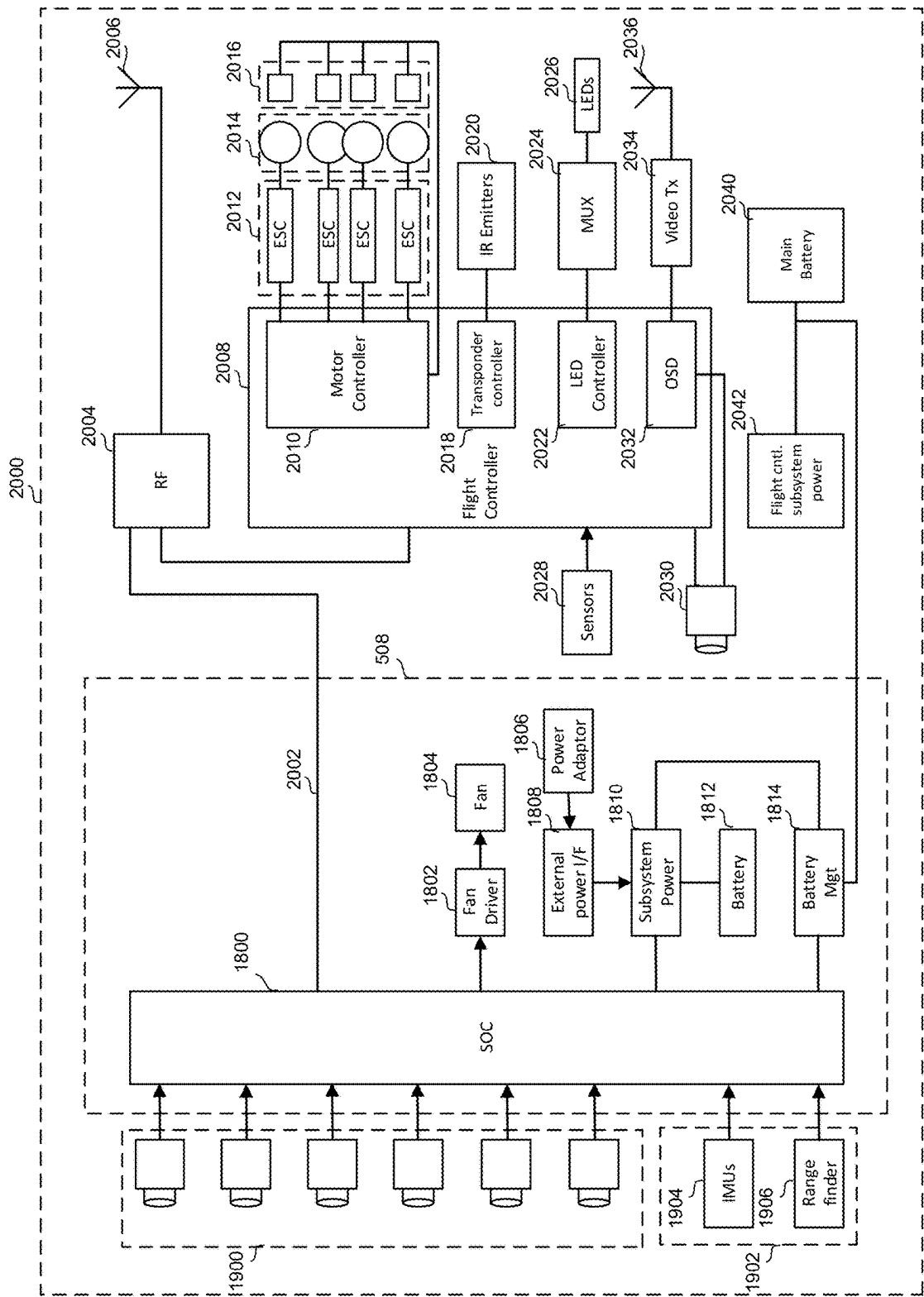


Figure 20

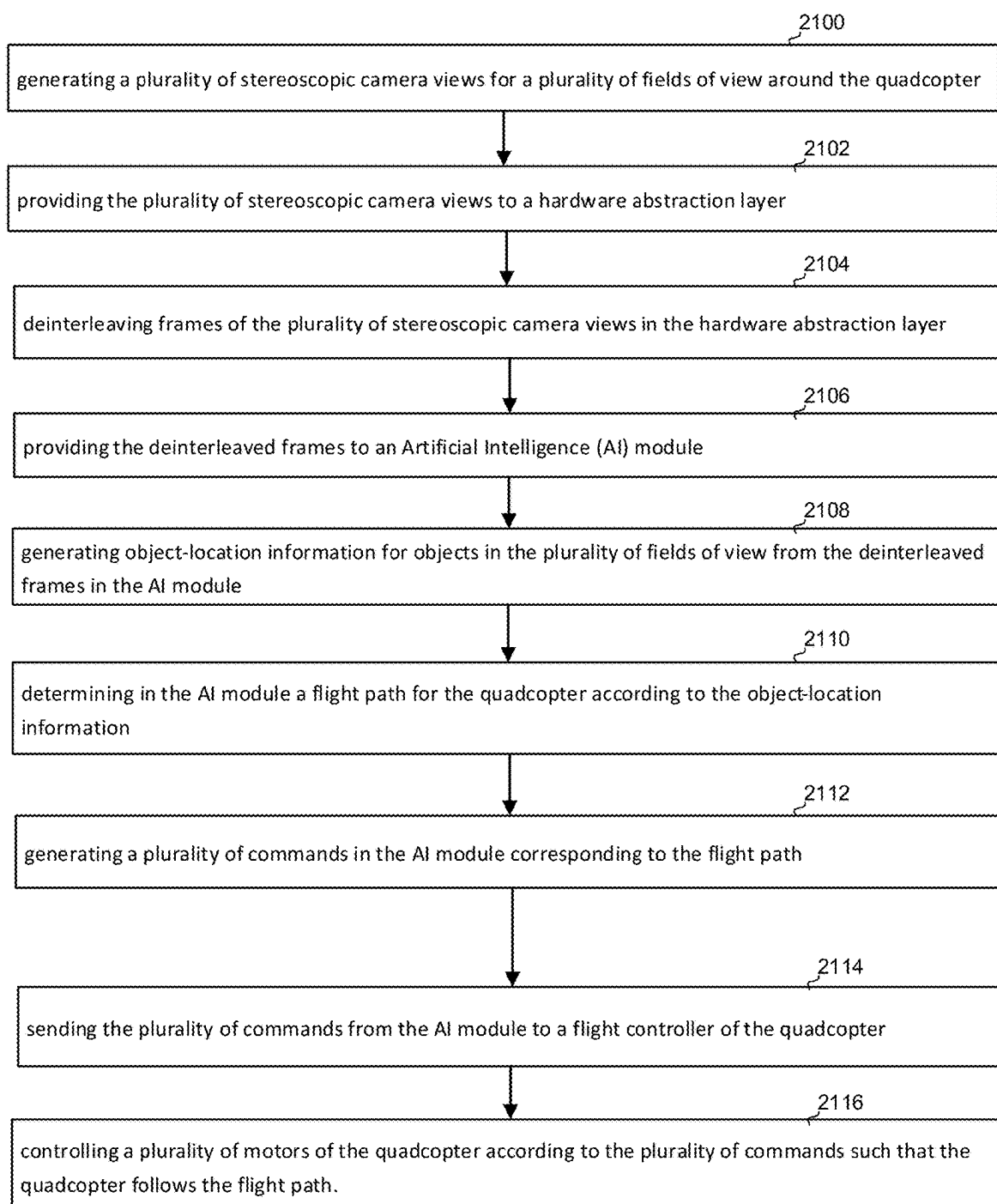


Figure 21

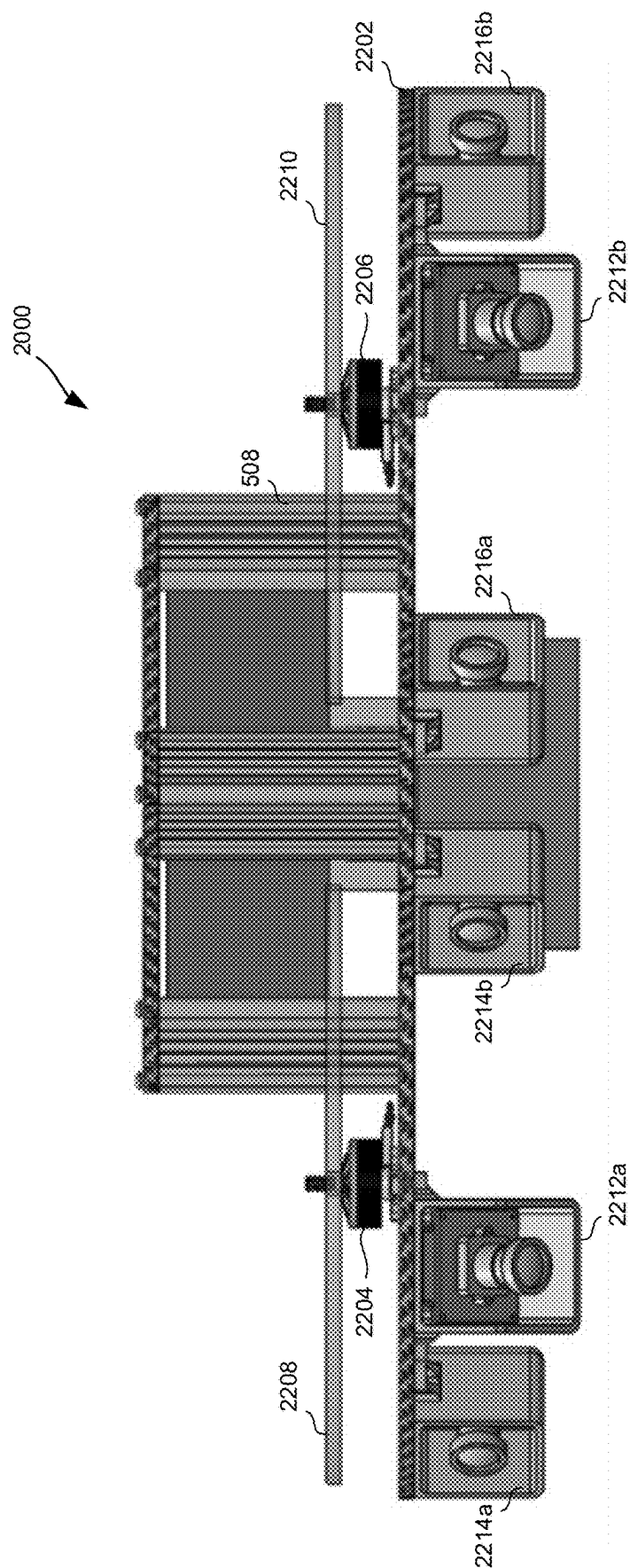


Figure 22A

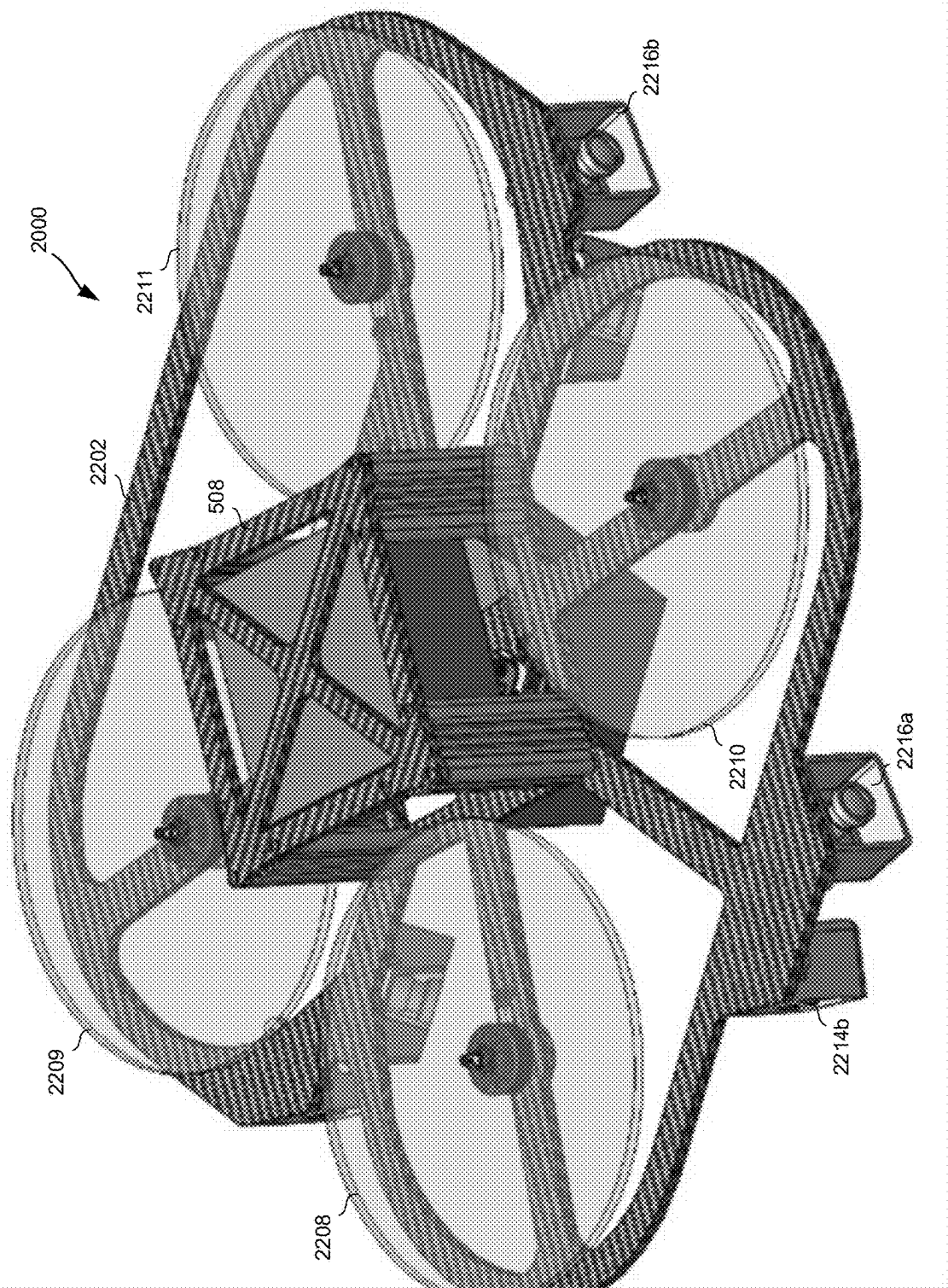


Figure 22B

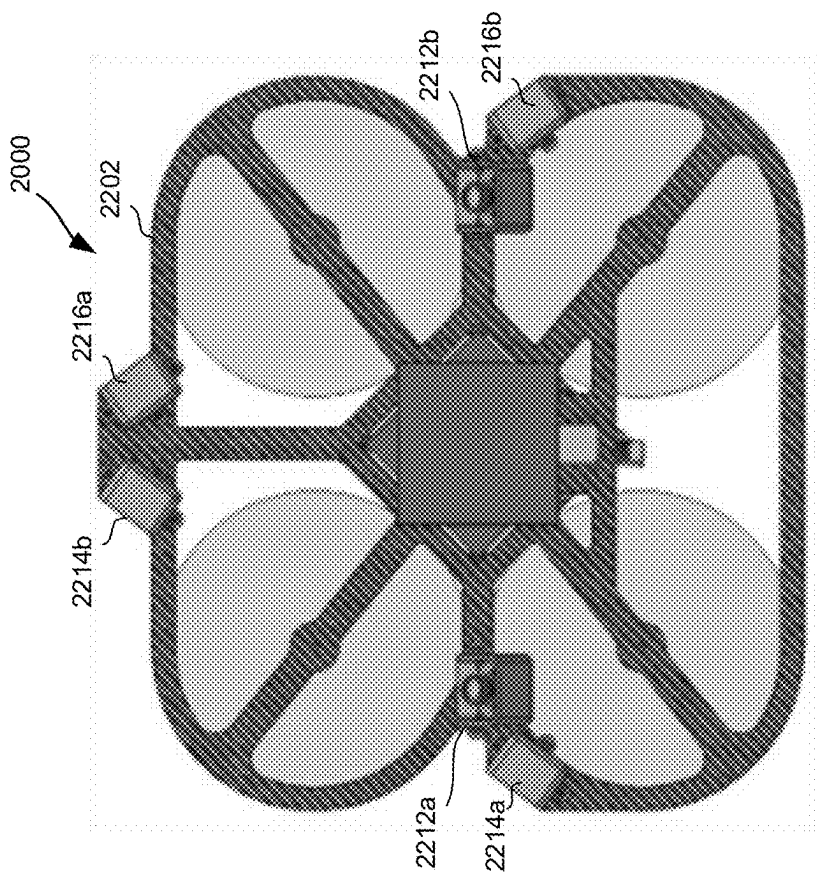


Figure 22D

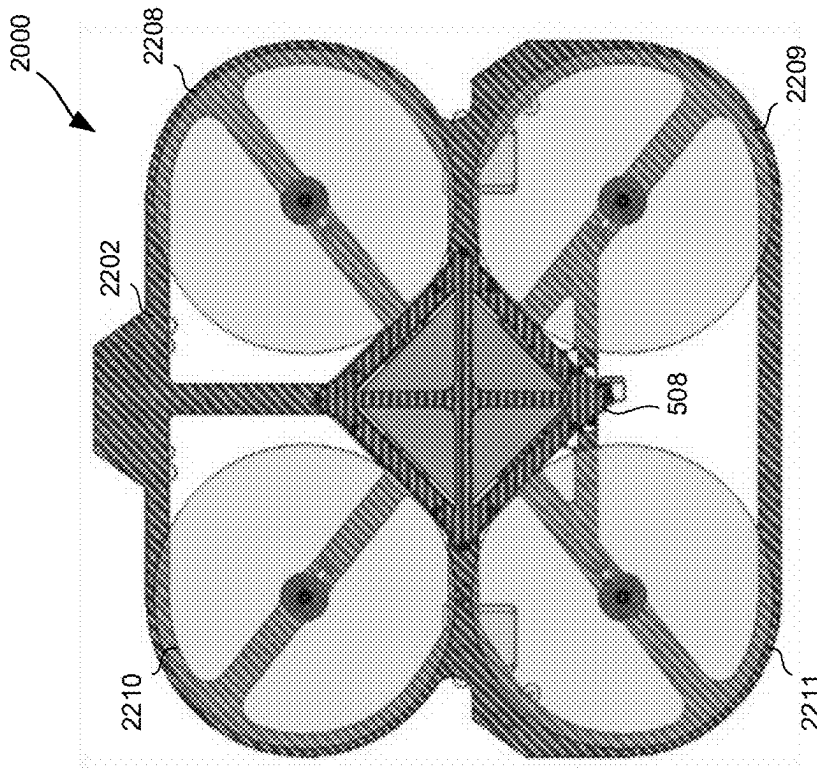


Figure 22C

MODULAR AUTONOMOUS DRONE

BACKGROUND

[0001] Radio controlled unmanned aircraft (e.g. drones, such as quadcopters) can move at high speed and make rapid changes in direction when remotely piloted by a skilled user. In drone racing, users race their respective drones around a course using remote-controls to maneuver around the course (e.g. through gates, around obstacles, etc.). A camera view from a drone may be relayed to a user to allow a First Person View (FPV) so that the user can see where the drone is going and steer it accordingly in the manner of a pilot sitting in the cockpit of an aircraft.

[0002] A drone may include a flight controller that provides output to motors and thus controls propeller speed to change thrust. For example, a quadcopter has four motors, each coupled to a corresponding propeller, with propellers mounted to generate thrust substantially in parallel (e.g. their axes of rotation may be substantially parallel). The flight controller may change speeds of the motors to change the orientation and velocity of the drone and the propellers may remain in a fixed orientation (i.e. without changing the angle of thrust with respect to the quadcopter) and may have fixed-pitch (i.e. propeller pitch may not be adjustable like a helicopter propeller so that each motor powers a corresponding fixed-pitch propeller in a fixed orientation with respect to a drone chassis). The flight controller may be directed by commands received from the user's remote-control and may generate outputs to motors to execute the commands.

SUMMARY OF THE DRAWINGS

[0003] FIG. 1 is a top view of an example of a course and a drone moving along a path through the course.

[0004] FIG. 2 is a simplified representation of some of the components for one embodiment of a quadcopter.

[0005] FIG. 3 shows an example of an autonomous quadcopter.

[0006] FIG. 4 shows an example of a method of developing AI code.

[0007] FIG. 5 shows an example of components of an AI controller coupled to a simulator.

[0008] FIG. 6A shows an example of an AI controller running AI piloting code coupled to a workstation implementing a quadcopter simulator.

[0009] FIG. 6B shows an example of a method operating an AI controller and quadcopter simulator.

[0010] FIG. 7 shows an example of AI controller operation.

[0011] FIG. 8 shows some components of an example Software Development Kit (SDK).

[0012] FIG. 9 shows an example of an Integrated Development Environment (IDE) features.

[0013] FIGS. 10A-C show aspects of an example of a quadcopter simulator.

[0014] FIG. 11 shows an example method of testing quadcopter components for simulation.

[0015] FIG. 12 shows an example of a test set-up for quadcopter component testing and characterization.

[0016] FIG. 13 shows an example of a method of obtaining simulated camera noise.

[0017] FIG. 14 shows an example of a method of obtaining simulated sensor noise.

[0018] FIG. 15 shows an example of a test set-up for quadcopter component noise measurement.

[0019] FIG. 16 shows an example of a workstation coupled to an AI controller for debugging AI piloting code while AI piloting code interacts with a simulator.

[0020] FIG. 17 shows an example of a method of debugging AI piloting code.

[0021] FIG. 18 shows an example of an AI controller coupled to a workstation.

[0022] FIG. 19 shows an example of an AI controller coupled to live hardware.

[0023] FIG. 20 shows an example of an AI controller in an autonomous drone.

[0024] FIG. 21 shows an example of a method of operating an autonomous drone.

[0025] FIGS. 22A-D show different views of an example of an autonomous drone.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0026] The following presents a system and techniques for an autonomous drone such as an autonomous quadcopter that includes an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller that is separate from a flight controller and that provides input to the flight controller to pilot the drone. The AI controller may provide all commands needed by the flight controller and thus may take the place of a user using a remote-control (e.g. a human pilot flying the drone by remote-control). The AI controller may use Computer Vision (CV) based on multiple cameras (e.g. six cameras configured as three stereoscopic cameras) to pilot the drone based on visual input from the environment, determining the flightpath in real time rather than flying along a predetermined flightpath. A drone equipped with such an AI controller may be an autonomous drone that does not require human input to fly around a course (e.g. a race course). The AI controller may be coupled to other drone components (e.g. flight controller) through a connector so that the AI controller is removable from the drone, allowing the drone to be configured for remote-control (without the AI controller) and for autonomous flight (with the AI controller). The drone may also be switchable between autonomous and remote-control modes without physically removing the AI controller (e.g. a remote-control may send a command to change from autonomous mode to remote-control mode during flight).

[0027] The AI controller may include modular components including libraries of routines that may be used for piloting a drone. An AI controller may be configured with a standardized set of modules for operation of standardized hardware and different teams may then develop AI code to interact with such standardized components in competition. For example, different AI code may be used in combination with other modules to race drones around a racecourse to compare performance of different AI code. In an example, participating teams may be provided with an AI controller preloaded with certain standardized modules and a workstation providing an Integrated Development Environment (IDE) for developing AI code. A drone simulator may be provided for testing AI code and a debugger may be provided for debugging AI code running on the AI controller while it is coupled to the simulator. An AI controller for use in an autonomous drone may be loaded with AI code, coupled to such a simulator and debugger, and may pilot

simulated drones around simulated environments (e.g. simulated racecourses) to debug, test, and teach (e.g. by machine learning) the AI code.

[0028] Debugging may include using accurate timestamping (e.g. Precision Time Protocol (PTP)) on both an AI controller and a drone simulator (e.g. quadcopter simulator) coupled to the AI controller. In case of an error in AI piloting code (or other event), timestamps may be used to rewind the drone simulator to (or past) the point where the error occurred (the error time). A debugger may then step through operations of the drone simulator and the AI piloting code to identify a source of an AI code error. A clock in the AI controller may be synchronized with a clock in a workstation that implements the drone simulator and the debugger so that timestamping is accurate across all hardware (e.g. using PTP hardware timestamps to achieve synchronization accuracy of less than one millisecond)

[0029] A drone simulator (e.g. quadcopter simulator) for use with an AI controller may include certain features to facilitate interaction with the AI controller. An AI controller may be more sensitive to small differences between simulated behavior and real behavior than a human pilot. For example, human pilots may compensate for some inaccuracy and may not even notice some discrepancies that may affect AI code. A drone simulator may be used to teach an AI controller (e.g. using machine learning) how to pilot a drone and the accuracy of such a drone simulator may subsequently affect how AI code pilots a real drone so that poor simulation may result in poor piloting (potentially including crashes or other unwanted consequences). In order to provide an accurate simulator, actual drone components may be characterized using bench testing to generate detailed characterization of different component characteristics across their operating ranges (rather than using simplified models that may not be as accurate). The test data can be used to generate detailed lookup tables for various characteristics under various conditions. Testing may be performed for a significant population of components (e.g. quadcopter motors, propellers, batteries, etc.) over different conditions (e.g. different current, power, RPM, battery charge) to obtain averaged data. The lookup tables may be used in a quadcopter simulator to provide extremely accurate simulation of a quadcopter that is suitable for providing to an AI controller.

[0030] Simulated sensor output and/or simulated camera output from a drone simulator may be modified to add simulated noise. In some cases, such simulated noise may be at a level that would not be noticed, or would not appear significant to a human pilot but may affect an AI pilot. Suitable simulated noise may be found from bench testing sensors and/or cameras. For example, creating constant conditions, recording sensor/camera output, and subtracting a constant signal to leave a noise component. A statistically significant population of sensors and/or cameras may be tested, and the test results combined (e.g. averaged) to obtain simulated noise that may then be added to simulated sensor output and/or simulated camera output. Such noise-added outputs may be provided to an AI controller and may be used by the AI controller to pilot a simulated drone.

[0031] Although the following description is primarily given the context of drones (e.g. quadcopters) moving along a three-dimensional path through a course (e.g. a racecourse where drones compete to go around the racecourse and reach a finish line by selecting the fastest flightpath), certain

concepts presented can be applied more generally. For example, the systems and techniques can be applied to non-drone aircraft or other objects that serve as a mobile source of the described signals as it moves along a three-dimensional path.

[0032] FIG. 1 is a top view of an example of a course and a drone moving along a path through the course. From the start location, the course passes through the gates G1-G6 **111-116** sequentially and then through an end gate EG **117** to arrive at the finish location. The drone **101** is shown moving along the path through the series of gates. A set of control transceivers cTx1-4 **151-154** cover the region that includes the course to supply control signals to drones on the course and also receive data back from the drones so that users, using remote-controls, may fly their drones and may see video from a camera on their drone (FPV). Although the start and finish of the course shown FIG. 1A are shown as near each other, this need not be so in general. Similarly, although the course is shown defined by a series of frame-like gates, pylons or other structures can be used to specify a course or path. While drone racing provides one area in which the present technology may be used, the present technology is not limited to racing and may be used to operate a variety of drones and other autonomous craft in a variety of environments.

[0033] FIG. 2 is simplified representation of some of the components for one example of a drone **201**, which is a remote-controlled quadcopter in this example. FIG. 2 shows flight controller **211** connected to motors **217a-d** (which turn respective propellers, not shown in this view), the voltage source and regulator **213**, wireless receiver **215**, video camera **231** and altitude sensor **233**, and the transmitters **225** and **227**. In this embodiment, extending on an arm from each of the corners of the drone is a motor **217a-d**, each of which is controlled by the flight controller **211** to thereby control thrust generated by propellers attached to motors **217a-d**. A voltage source (e.g. battery) and regulator **213** supplies power. A pilot's commands are transmitted from control signal transceivers such as cTx **223**, received by wireless receiver **215**. Control signal transceiver cTx **223** may be in a remote-control operated by a pilot (remote-control user) to fly drone **201**. The flight controller **211** uses power from the voltage source **213** to drive the motors **217a-d** according to the pilot's signals.

[0034] The drone also includes video camera **231** and altitude sensor **233** that supply data to the flight controller **211**. An FM or other type video transmitter **225** transmits data from the video camera **231** to a video monitor receiver vRx **221** (external to the drone, such as on the ground) that monitors the video signals and passes on the video data to the pilot. Data can also be sent back to the control signal transceiver cTx **223** by the transmitter **227**. Although the transmitter **227** and wireless receiver **215** are shown as separate elements in FIG. 2, in many embodiments these will be part of a single transceiver module (e.g. a remote-control may include both a control signal transceiver and a video monitor receiver to allow a remote-control user to see video from video camera **231** while piloting drone **201**).

[0035] FIG. 3 shows an example of an autonomous drone **301** (autonomous quadcopter in this example), which is different to drone **201** in that it is configured for autonomous operation, instead of, or in addition to receiving commands from a remote user. For example, autonomous drone **301** may fly around a course such as illustrated in FIG. 1,

maneuvering through gates, around obstacles, etc. without commands from a remote user. Instead of receiving commands via RF communication from a remote-control, when in autonomous mode, autonomous drone **301** may operate according to commands generated by an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller **330**, which is coupled to the flight controller **211** (components of autonomous drone **301** that are common to drone **201** are similarly labeled). In this arrangement, AI controller **330** selects a flightpath and generates commands according to the same command set used by a remote-control. Thus, remote unit **332** may send commands to flight controller **211** according to a predetermined command set when autonomous drone **301** is in a remote-control mode. AI controller **330** may send commands to flight controller **211** according to the same predetermined command set when autonomous drone **301** is in an autonomous mode. In this way, flight controller **211** may operate similarly in both remote-control mode and autonomous modes and does not require reconfiguration. This allows drones developed for remote-control to be easily adapted for autonomous operation, thus taking advantage of preexisting components and shortening development time for autonomous quadcopter development.

[0036] In an example, AI controller **330** may be implemented in an AI module that may be considered as a bolt-on component that may be added to a fully-functional drone (e.g. instead of, or in addition to a remote-control). For example, AI controller **330** may be implemented by a controller module, such as an NVIDIA Jetson AGX Xavier module, which includes a Central Processing Unit (CPU), Graphics Processing Unit (GPU), memory (e.g. volatile memory such as DRAM or SRAM), data storage (e.g. non-volatile data storage such as flash), and Vision accelerator. Other suitable controller hardware may also be used. The AI controller **330** may be connected to flight controller **211** and other quadcopter components through a physical connector to allow it to be connected/disconnected for configuration for AI control/remote-control. AI controller **330** may be physically attached to autonomous drone **301** by being clipped on, bolted on, or otherwise attached (e.g. to the chassis of drone **301**) in a manner that makes physical removal easy.

[0037] While a human pilot may fly a drone based on video sent to the pilot from the drone, an AI pilot, such as embodied in AI controller **330** may pilot a drone based on different input including sensor input and/or input from multiple cameras (e.g. using Computer Vision (CV) to identify and locate features in its environment). While human pilots generally rely on a single camera to provide a single view (first person view, or “FPV”), an AI pilot may use a plurality of cameras that cover different areas (e.g. a wider field of view, more than 180 degrees and as much as 360 degrees). In an example, cameras may be arranged in pairs, with a pair of cameras having overlapping fields of view. This allows such a pair of cameras to form a stereoscopic camera so that depth of field information may be extracted by a CV unit. FIG. 3 illustrates an example of camera **334a** and camera **334b**, which are arranged with overlapping fields of view to form a stereoscopic camera **334**. Similarly, cameras **336a** and **336b** form stereoscopic camera **336** and cameras **338a** and **338b** form stereoscopic camera **338**. It will be understood that the orientations (different angles corresponding to different views) and locations of cameras shown in FIG. 3 are illustrative and that the

number, location, arrangement, and pairing of such cameras may be varied according to requirements (e.g. more than three stereoscopic cameras may be used). In the example of FIG. 3, video outputs of all cameras, **334a**, **334b**, **336a**, **336b**, **338a**, and **338b** (and any other cameras) are sent to AI controller **330**. While one or more video output may be transmitted to an external location (e.g. transmitted by transmitter/receiver **340** to remote unit **332**), in some cases no such transmission is performed when autonomous drone **301** is in autonomous mode. In some cases, an autonomous drone such as autonomous drone **301** is configurable to receive commands from a remote-control such as remote unit **332** (e.g. may be remote-controlled at certain times, e.g. according to selection by a remote user) through a communication circuit. These commands may use the same command set so that commands from AI controller **330** and remote unit **332** are interchangeable. Transmitter/receiver **340** may be considered an example of a Radio Frequency (RF) communication circuit coupled to the flight controller **211**, the RF communication circuit (e.g. RF receiver) is configured to receive external commands from a remote-control (e.g. remote unit **332**) and provide the external commands to the flight controller **211** to direct the flight controller to follow a remotely-selected flightpath, the external commands and the commands provided by the AI controller **330** from a common command set.

[0038] AI controller **330** includes computer vision (CV) capability to interpret input from cameras **334a**, **334b**, **336a**, **336b**, **338a**, and **338b** to gain information about the environment around drone **301** (e.g. object identification and location). Stereoscopic cameras **334**, **336**, **338** are configured to obtain different stereoscopic views to allow depth of field analysis so that the proximity of objects (including racecourse features such as gates, drones, and other racecourse features) may be accurately determined. AI controller **330** may use CV capability to generate a three-dimensional (3-D) picture of the surrounding of autonomous drone **301**, or a portion of the surroundings (e.g. generally ahead of autonomous drone **301** along its direction of travel). In some cases, multiple cameras may be used to collectively provide a full 360-degree field of view. In other cases, cameras may cover less than 360 degrees but may still collectively cover a larger field of view than a human pilot could effectively monitor. Video output from cameras **334a**, **334b**, **336a**, **336b**, **338a**, and **338b** may be directly provided to AI controller **330** without conversion to RF and transmission as used by remote-controlled drones (e.g. remote-controlled quadcopters). This may allow rapid reaction as drone **301** moves and video output reflects changing surroundings (e.g. reduced latency may allow faster response than with remote-control).

[0039] AI controller **330** is coupled to the plurality of cameras **334a**, **334b**, **336a**, **336b**, **338a**, and **338b** to receive input from the plurality of cameras, determine a flightpath for the autonomous quadcopter (e.g. drone **301**) according to the input from the plurality of cameras, and provide commands to the flight controller **211** to direct the flight controller **211** to follow the flightpath. Thus, the role of flight controller **211** is to execute commands from AI controller **330** (as it would from a remote-control user), while AI controller makes piloting decisions based on video input (and, in some cases, other input, e.g. from sensors). AI controller **330** may be considered an example of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to a plurality of cameras

(e.g. cameras **334**, **336**, **338**) to receive input from the plurality of cameras, determine a flightpath for the autonomous quadcopter **301** according to the input from the plurality of cameras, and provide commands to the flight controller **211** to direct the flight controller to follow the flightpath. Flight controller **211** is coupled to the four motors **217a-d** to provide input to the four motors to control flight of the autonomous quadcopter **301**.

[0040] In addition to cameras **334a**, **334b**, **336a**, **336b**, **338a**, and **338b**, autonomous drone **301** includes Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU) sensors **342** and rangefinder **344**. IMU sensors **342** may measure one or more of specific force, angular rate, and magnetic field using a combination of accelerometers (acceleration sensors), gyroscopes (gyroscopic sensors), and magnetometers to generate motion data (e.g. autonomous quadcopter motion data). For example, IMU sensors **342** may be used as a gyroscope and accelerometer to obtain orientation and acceleration measurements. Rangefinder **344** (which may be considered a distance or range sensor) measures the distance from autonomous drone **301** to an external feature (e.g. the ground, obstacle or gate along a racecourse, etc.) Rangefinder **344** may use a laser to determine distance (e.g. pulsed laser, or Light Detection and Ranging “LiDAR”). Outputs from sensors **342** and **344** are provided to AI controller **330** in this example. Outputs from such sensors may also be provided to a flight controller (e.g. flight controller **211**) in some cases. In addition to the sensors illustrated, an autonomous drone may include other sensors such as a barometer, or altimeter, to determine height of a drone above ground, and/or LIDAR sensors using lasers to generate 3-D representations of surroundings. In some cases, a Global Positioning System (GPS) module may be provided to provide position information based on communication with GPS satellites.

[0041] AI controller **330** may be in the form of a removable module that is added to a drone to provide capacity for autonomous operation. Within AI controller **330**, certain modules may be provided with different functions. In an example, different AI technologies may be compared side-by-side by loading AI controllers with different AI code and flying drones using the different AI code (e.g. in a race) to compare AI technologies. In such an example, certain basic functions of AI controller **330** may be provided by standard modules that are common to multiple AI controllers while other functions may be customized by a particular module, or modules, that are then compared by flying drones with identical drone hardware, AI controller hardware, and some identical modules within AI controllers provide a comparison of AI technologies without effects of different hardware and/or software differences unrelated to AI piloting. According to an example, autonomous drone racing uses different AI technologies in identical autonomous drones. This eliminates hardware differences. Certain common software may be provided in standard AI controllers to provide a common platform (common hardware and software elements) that accommodates different AI technologies and allows them to compete on an equal footing. This provides development teams with an opportunity to focus on core technology, reduces cost, and reduces development time. Racing drones around complex courses provides comparison between different candidate AI technologies and can identify winning candidates for further development. This provides valuable information, reduces wasted resources on unpromising tech-

nologies, and rapid identification of winning technologies reduces overall development time and cost.

[0042] FIG. 4 illustrates an example of a method of developing AI technology which may be used in an autonomous drone, e.g. used in AI controller **330** of autonomous drone **301**. The method of FIG. 3 generates AI code in multiple iterations, with testing of AI code using a simulator (e.g. quadcopter simulator) to test AI code at each iteration. The simulator may be implemented using a workstation that is coupled to an AI controller. The simulator may have some features in common with drone simulators used by human pilots. However, differences between human controlled flight (through remote-control) and autonomous flight may result in important differences in such simulators and in how they are coupled to pilots.

[0043] The method of FIG. 4 may be used by multiple teams of AI developers (participants) to develop AI code for flying autonomous drones (e.g. to develop AI code for AI controller **330**). Development of AI code in FIG. 4 occurs without the use of actual drones so that, in the case of any failure (e.g. crash, collision, etc.), no hardware is destroyed so that development costs are not impacted by hardware repair and replacement. Only after the AI code is tested against a simulator is it deployed for use to fly drones. In some cases, simulation may include some hardware elements (Hardware-in-the-loop, or HITL testing). However, this generally occurs on a testbench or other test environment where a limited number of components (e.g. cameras, sensors, etc.) may be tested without actually flying a drone. Thus, destruction of hardware components during development is generally avoided or reduced.

[0044] In the method of FIG. 4, a software development kit (SDK), or “Dev kit” and workstation are sent to a participant **450** (e.g. to each participant of a group of participants). The SDK may include software components to facilitate generating AI code. Sample projects may be provided for participants to check and become familiar with the system. The SDK may be implemented using an AI controller (e.g. AI controller **330**) that may be sent with the SDK and may be preloaded with appropriate software modules. The participant then performs hardware setup **452**, for example, coupling the AI controller to a workstation and connecting any hardware components. A self-test routine **454** may be performed to check for hardware problems (e.g. ensure coupling between workstation and AI controller). A sample AI code module may be provided as part of the SDK. A participant may modify sample AI code **456** in order to improve the sample code, e.g. by adding additional AI code to the sample AI code according to the participant’s technology. The AI code may be written and debugged using an Integrated Development Environment (IDE) that is provided to the participant. This may be a customized IDE based on an available IDE such as the Eclipse IDE from the Eclipse Foundation. The participant may then run the AI code against the simulator **458**. For example, AI code developed by the participant may be loaded into the AI controller, which is coupled to a workstation that includes drone simulation software. The AI controller may interact with the simulator to simulate flying of a drone. Subsequently, a participant may run the AI code against test bed hardware **460**. For example, a test bed may include components such as cameras, sensors, batteries, motors, so that the AI code can be verified with some hardware components in addition to a simulator. A participant may then review results, e.g.

sensor logs, telemetry, video **464** to evaluate the performance of the AI code. Based on this review, a determination may be made as to whether the AI code is ready **466**, e.g. ready to deploy to an actual drone. In general, multiple iterations may be required to produce AI code that is ready to deploy. When a determination is made that the AI code is not ready, a determination is made as to whether support is needed **468**. For example, the results of running AI code against the simulator and/or hardware may indicate a problem that requires help from the SDK provider and/or hardware provider or other entity. If such support is indicated, then the participant may contact support **470**. If no such support is indicated, then the participant may further modify sample AI code **456** and commence another iteration of modification and testing. When the participant generates AI code that is determined to be ready **466**, this AI code may be deployed **472**, e.g. by loading it in an AI controller of an actual drone and using it to autonomously pilot the drone (e.g. racing a real quadcopter, under control of the AI controller, around a racecourse). By running AI code to fly a simulator over multiple iterations in this way, the risk of crashing an actual drone is reduced and thus costs are reduced. Different AI code versions of AI piloting code may be generated in different iterations and compared to select an AI code version for deployment (e.g. according to the fastest time piloting a simulated quadcopter around a simulated quadcopter racecourse).

[0045] Some of the hardware and software components used in the process of FIG. 4 are illustrated in FIG. 5. For example, a simulator **502** is shown that includes simulated sensors **504** (e.g. simulated accelerometer, simulated gyroscope, simulated rangefinder, etc.) and simulated cameras **506**. Simulator **502** may be implemented on a workstation that is configured by simulator software to simulate a drone such as a quadcopter. The features of simulator **502** may be customized according to the drone to be simulated and its hardware components. Thus, simulated sensors **504** may provide simulation of any sensors to be included in an actual drone. These may include one or more IMU sensors, rangefinder sensors, LIDAR sensors, altimeter sensors and/or other sensors. Output from simulated sensors **504** may be sent in a format that conforms to a standard suitable for sensor output. For example, simulated sensor output may be sent in User Datagram Protocol (UDP) format, or other format that may be used by actual sensors of a drone.

[0046] Simulated cameras **506** may generate simulated views from multiple cameras of a simulated drone. In general, simulation is adapted to the hardware to be simulated so that for simulation of a quadcopter with six cameras arranged as three stereoscopic cameras (e.g. stereoscopic cameras **334**, **336**, **338** of quadcopter **301**) simulated cameras **506** produce six simulated camera outputs. These outputs may be provided in any suitable format. For example, where simulator **502** is implemented as a workstation, High-Definition Multimedia Interface (HDMI) ports may be provided and camera outputs may be sent in HDMI format through such HDMI ports. AI controller **508** also generates inputs to simulator **502**, including commands to simulator **502** that correspond to changes in drone orientation and/or direction.

[0047] FIG. 5 also shows live hardware **510**, which includes sensors **512** (e.g. one or more IMU, magnetometer, rangefinder, lidar, altimeter, and/or other sensor(s)) and cameras **514** (e.g. multiple cameras forming one or more

stereoscopic cameras. Live hardware **510** may include additional drone hardware components such as motors, batteries, power controllers, etc. Live hardware **510** may be used in conjunction with simulator **502** to test AI controller **508** and, for example, to test AI code (e.g. participant code **520**) operating on controller **508**. Live hardware **510** may be operated on a test bench with individual components operated separately, or in combination. In some cases, a complete drone may be provided as live hardware. AI code operating on AI controller **508** may be run against simulator **502** (as shown at step **458** of FIG. 4) and subsequently run against live hardware **510** (as shown at step **460** of FIG. 4). Simulator **502** and live hardware **510** may be interchangeable (e.g. using the same connectors) so that simulator **502** may be disconnected from AI controller **508** prior to connecting live hardware **510**.

[0048] FIG. 5 illustrates modules of AI controller **508** including hardware abstraction layer **516** which abstracts input from simulator **502** and live hardware **510** so that the input is available to other components of AI controller **508** in abstracted form and other components do not have to perform conversion. For example, hardware abstraction layer **516** may receive interleaved camera output (e.g. alternating frames, or interleaved line-by-line, or otherwise interleaved) from a plurality of cameras (simulated cameras **506** and/or cameras **514**), deinterleave the input to regenerate frames from individual cameras, and separately buffer the frames for different cameras (e.g. buffered in ROM) so that a sequence of frames for a given camera may be provided at the correct frame rate (e.g. a predetermined frame rate such as 60 Hz) to components of AI controller **508** that may require video input. In an example, video output from two cameras or simulated cameras (e.g. a pair of cameras forming a stereoscopic camera) that are interleaved may be deinterleaved, buffered, and made available to modules such as a CV module that may then use the video. Hardware abstraction layer **516** may abstract sensor input (from simulated or real sensors) and buffer sensor data received at speed so that it is presented at the correct frame rate (e.g. by mapping kernel memory to user memory).

[0049] AI controller **508** includes different modules to perform different functions. An AI master **518** is responsible for running AI code including routines from other components. AI master **518** may also interact with simulator **502**, with a debugger, and may perform other functions that are not directly involved with piloting a drone. Participant code **520** is code written or modified by participants. While other components shown in FIG. 5 may be common to all participants, each participant may create their own participant code. FIG. 4 showed a method for development of participant code, such as participant code **520**, through modification of participant code (sample AI code) in multiple iterations while other modules remain unchanged from iteration to iteration. AI controller **508** includes pre-installed libraries **522** and a helper library **524**. These libraries may include various libraries of software routines that may be available for operation of a drone. For example, pre-installed libraries **522** may include various publicly available libraries that participant code may use while helper library **524** may include routines that are customized for drone operation and may be provided by as part of an SDK to make development of participant code simpler and quicker.

[0050] FIG. 6A illustrates an example of physical connections between components of FIG. 5, including coupling of

simulator **502** (running on workstation **628**) to AI controller **508**. The arrangement of FIG. **6A** may be used to implement the method illustrated in FIG. **4**. Simulator **502** generates six simulated camera outputs that form three simulated stereoscopic camera outputs by pairing simulated camera outputs from simulated cameras that have overlapping fields of view. Outputs from a pair of cameras may be sent over an HDMI connection in an interleaved format or combined in another way. For example, two or more lower-resolution frames may be combined in a single frame, e.g. two frames of simulated camera output with **1280x720** pixels may be combined in a single frame of **1920x1200** pixels. FIG. **6A** shows three HDMI cables **630**, **631**, **632** from workstation **628**. Each HDMI cable **630**, **631**, **632** may be connected to a corresponding HDMI port of workstation **628** and may carry interleaved output of two simulated cameras that form a simulated stereoscopic camera. HDMI cables **630**, **631**, **632** are connected to HDMI to MIPI bridge **634**, which converts from HDMI format to MIPI CSI (Mobile Industry Processor Interface Camera Serial Interface, e.g. CSI-2 or CSI-3) format (and may also be referred to as an HDMI to MIPI converter). The interleaved MIPI output of HDMI to MIPI bridge **634** may be deinterleaved by a hardware abstraction layer in AI controller **508** (e.g. by HAL **516**). While FIG. **6A** shows HDMI to MIPI bridge **634** as a single entity, this may be implemented by any suitable hardware. For example, three separate bridges may be used to form HDMI to MIPI bridge **634**, with each such bridge converting one HDMI output to a corresponding MIPI output.

[**0051**] In addition to HDMI and MIPI cables to carry camera data from simulator **502** in workstation **628** to AI controller **508**, FIG. **6A** shows a coupling **636** to carry simulated sensor data from simulator **502** to AI controller **508**. Simulated sensor data may be sent over coupling **636** in the form of UDP packets to provide simple low-latency communication suitable for sensor data. Simulated sensor data may be packetized in UDP packets, which are time stamped, and have redundancy code added (e.g. calculation and addition of a Cyclic Redundancy Code such as CRC**16**) and streamed to AI controller **508**. FIG. **6A** also shows coupling **637** to carry commands from AI controller **508** to simulator **502**. For example, such commands may use a command set that is suitable for drone operation, such as a command set that may be used for remote-control of a drone, e.g. a command set according to the MAVLink protocol, or a MAVLink-like command set. FIG. **6A** also shows coupling **638**, which is configured to convey logging, debugging, and control data between AI controller **508** and workstation **628** where a debugger **629** may perform debugging of AI code operation in AI Controller **508** as AI Controller **508** pilots a simulated drone of simulator **502**. Logging data may include logs of commands and variables that may be sent from AI controller **508** to debugger **629**. Debugging data may include data regarding the state of AI controller **508** at a breakpoint (e.g. variable values), timing information, and other data that may be useful to debugger **629**. Control data may include commands from debugger to AI code and/or debug-related code operating on AI controller **508**. Coupling **637** to carry commands and coupling **638** to carry logging, debugging and control data may be implemented using Transfer Control Protocol (TCP), which is a connection-oriented protocol to ensure that a connection is established, and that commands and other communication are received. While couplings **636**, **637**, **638** may be implemented in any

suitable manner, in the present example these couplings are implemented through an Ethernet connection **640** so that a single physical connection may be used for these different purposes. Simulator **502** may include an Ethernet port that is dedicated to communication with AI controller **508** for this purpose.

[**0052**] Simulator **502** is also connected to network **642** by coupling **644**. For example, coupling **644** may be an Ethernet connection and network **642** may be an intranet or the Internet. Thus, simulator **502** may include an Ethernet port for communication with external entities in addition to an Ethernet port dedicated to communication with AI controller **508**. In order to avoid conflicts, a dedicated IP address range may be reserved for communication between simulator **502** and AI controller **508**. For example, the IP address range **100.64.0.0/16**, which is within a private IP address range may be used so that no conflict occurs. Simulator **502** may be assigned IP address **100.64.0.1** and AI controller may be assigned IP address **100.64.1.1**.

[**0053**] FIG. **6A** may be considered an example of a quadcopter simulator **502** configured to receive quadcopter flight control commands and to generate simulated sensor output and simulated camera output for a plurality of stereoscopic cameras of a simulated quadcopter, and an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller **508** coupled to the quadcopter simulator, the AI controller configured to receive the simulated sensor output and the simulated camera output for the plurality of stereoscopic cameras from the quadcopter simulator, determine a flightpath for the simulated quadcopter according to the simulated sensor output and the simulated camera output, generate the quadcopter flight control commands according to the flightpath, and provide the quadcopter flight control commands to the quadcopter simulator.

[**0054**] FIG. **6B** shows an example of a method that includes generating, in a quadcopter simulator, a plurality of simulated stereoscopic camera views (with different orientations) of a simulated environment around a simulated quadcopter having a position and orientation in the simulated environment **650**, sending the plurality of simulated stereoscopic camera views to a quadcopter Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller that is configured to autonomously pilot a simulated quadcopter according to the plurality of simulated stereoscopic camera views **652**, determining, by the AI controller, a flight path for the simulated quadcopter according to the plurality of simulated stereoscopic camera views **654**, and generating, in the AI controller, a plurality of flight control commands to pilot the simulated quadcopter along the flight path **656**. The method further includes sending the plurality of flight control commands to the quadcopter simulator **658** and in the quadcopter simulator, simulating execution of the plurality of flight control commands to obtain updated position and orientation for the simulated quadcopter and repeating generating of simulated stereoscopic camera views for the updated position and orientation in the simulated environment **660**.

[**0055**] FIG. **7** illustrates operation of components of AI controller **508** shown in FIG. **5** when coupled to a simulator to pilot a simulated drone as shown in FIG. **6**, or when piloting an actual drone (e.g. when AI controller **508** is coupled to a flight controller of a drone such as flight controller **211** of drone **301**). AI controller **508** may be a suitable controller such as the NVIDIA Jetson AGX Xavier, which includes CPU cores, GPU cores, deep learning accel-

erators (DLAs), and a programmable vision accelerator (PVA) suitable for computer vision applications (e.g. may form a computer vision unit) and machine learning. AI master **518** handles out of band communication with the IDE, e.g. communication with debugger **629** operating on workstation **628** and AI master **518** runs loops for hardware abstraction layer **516** and participant code **520**.

[0056] Data flows into hardware abstraction layer **516** (HAL) from either actual sensors (on a drone or test bench) or from a simulator such as simulator **502** (over UDP). The HAL **516** provides a common interface for the user code across any implementation (e.g. with a simulator such as simulator **502**, with hardware components provided with the development kit or other test bench hardware, and with hardware of an actual drone) by abstracting sensor data (e.g. gyroscope, accelerometer, magnetometer, rangefinder) into abstract base classes. HAL **516** also abstracts camera feeds to generate abstracted input for computer vision. Participant code **520** reaches into HAL **516** for all communications, including incoming communications from sensors and cameras and outgoing communications to a flight controller. Communication from participant code **520** to drone hardware (and simulated hardware) passes through HAL **516** so that participant code **520** can provide commands at a high level and HAL **516** then converts these commands to lower-level commands, e.g. providing commands to a flight controller in terms of thrust, pitch, roll, and yaw according to a command protocol such as MAVLink-like protocol, or other such protocol.

[0057] Participant code **520** uses process scheduler **750** to run in either fixed frequency loops, with data synchronized, or can be scheduled to run a callback at an arbitrary time. Participant code **520** may call routines from helper library **524**, which may call (or include) routines from pre-installed libraries **522**, including NVIDIA libraries **752** (e.g. VisionWorks, CUDA, CUDA Deep Neural Network library (cuDNN)), OpenCV libraries **754** (e.g. CUDA accelerated), and TensorFlow libraries **756**. Participant code **520** may also directly call routines from pre-installed libraries **522**. Helper library **524** has a common interface across all platforms (e.g. simulator, test bench hardware, actual drone hardware) and may include a light wrapper for some common computer vision tasks, algorithms, and data structures, as well as control of the drone, which goes through HAL **516**.

[0058] Further details of software components that may be included in pre-installed libraries **522** are illustrated in FIG. **8**. FIG. **8** shows NVIDIA libraries **752** including NVIDIA VisionWorks **860** (a software development package for computer vision and image processing, which may form part of a computer vision unit), Deep Learning SDK **862** (tools and libraries for designing GPU-accelerated deep learning applications), TensorRT **864** (a platform for deep-learning inference), cuDNN **866** (a GPU-accelerated library of primitives for deep neural networks), and CUDA toolkit **868** (a development environment for creating high-performance GPU-accelerated applications). FIG. **8** also shows OpenCV **754** (an open source computer vision library, which may be considered a CV unit, or part of a CV unit), TensorFlow **756** (an open source software library for high performance machine learning and numerical computation), Point Cloud Library **870** (an open-source library of algorithms for point cloud processing tasks and 3D geometry processing, e.g. for 3D computer vision), SLAM libraries **872** (libraries related to Simultaneous Localization And Mapping, or “SLAM”

e.g. ORB-SLAM2, YOLO, etc.), Object detectors **874** (this may include elements in addition to object detection elements in OpenCV **754** and TensorFlow **756** libraries). In addition to pre-installed libraries **522**, an SDK **876** that is provided to participants may include drone navigation Application Programming Interface (API) **878** to facilitate development of participant code and machine learning training sets **880** that may include training sets that are specific to features to be encountered by drones (e.g. racecourse components such as gates, obstacles, and other drones for racing drones). These may be used by machine learning code (e.g. in participant code **520**) so that such code learns at least some basic piloting from such training sets.

[0059] FIG. **9** illustrates some features of an Integrated Development Environment (IDE) **984** that may be used to develop AI code such as participant code **520**. IDE **984** may include elements of SDK **876** shown in FIG. **8**, with additional elements, and may be provided to participants for use in a development process as illustrated in FIG. **4**. This provides a large number of features to a participant so that the participant does not have to develop these features and can focus on AI code for flying a drone. The IDE provides a participant with IDE features **984** including general IDE features **986**, which include code assistance **988**. Code assistance **988** includes features such as syntax highlighting **990** (allowing source code to be displayed in different colors and/or fonts according to the category of code terms), code completion **992** (e.g. providing popups querying parameters of functions and identifying syntax errors) and jump to documentation **994** (allowing a direct jump from an editor to related documentation). General IDE features **986** also include debugging **996**, which includes features such as set breakpoints **998** (allowing a user to set breakpoints in AI code for debugging purposes) and inspect variables **902** (allowing a user to get variable values at a breakpoint). General IDE features **986** also include profiling/instrumentation features **904**, such as run-time metrics **906** (showing metrics such as load and memory usage) and CPU/GPU usage **908** (displaying CPU/GPU usage to user). General IDE features **986** also include Deploy features **910**, such as deploy to simulator features **912** (to facilitate deployment to a simulator such as simulator **502** implemented in workstation **628**) and deploy to test bed features **914** (to facilitate deployment to a test bed with hardware components, e.g. live hardware **510**).

[0060] In addition to General IDE features **986**, IDE features **984** include data acquisition/analysis features **916**, such as Sensor/camera features **917** and MATLAB-like plotting and charting via Python & Matplotlib **922**. Sensor/camera features **917** include import data from simulator **918** (to import simulated sensor/camera from a simulator, such as simulator **502**, for use by an AI controller running AI code) and import data from test bed **920** (to import data from actual sensors/cameras on a test bench, such as live hardware **510**, for use by an AI controller running AI code). MATLAB-like plotting and charting via Python & Matplotlib **922** includes features such as Plot point clouds **924**, plot sensor readings **926**, and plot position and derivatives **928** (to plot these elements to provide graphical illustration for users). MATLAB-like plotting and charting via Python & Matplotlib **922** also includes the feature view SLAM maps **930** to allow a user to view maps related to location and mapping.

[0061] IDE features **984** also include Drone Programming Assists **930**, including features such as AI building blocks **932** and Navigation **942**. AI Building Blocks **932** includes Kalman filters **934** (to estimate unknown variables from statistical data), SLAM algorithms **936** (algorithms related to localization and mapping), drone detection **938** (to detect other drones for collision-avoidance or other purposes), and ArUco Mapping **940** (a library for Augmented Reality (AR) applications based on OpenCV). Navigation **942** features include vector-based features **944** (including conversion of navigation data to SBUS protocol), manual SBUS **946**, and basic commands **948** (a set of commands that may be MAVLink commands or MAVLink-like so that a common command set is used between AI controllers and simulators, test bench hardware, and live drone hardware). It should be noted that the features illustrated in the example of FIG. 9 is not intended to be exhaustive and that an actual IDE may provide additional features, or may omit one or more of the features shown. Furthermore, participants may choose which features to use and how to use them.

[0062] IDE features **984** shown provide the user with various capabilities including the following:

[0063] Produce an AI module which will let the user execute code in one of several threads, in either C or Python (may not be 100% parity between Python and C, but definitely useful for prototyping).

[0064] Output of the build is a shared object which gets loaded by the master AI process and executed sequentially.

[0065] Interact with the simulator.

[0066] Debug their code.

[0067] It may do this, for example, by using Eclipse IDE as a basis to provide a strong IDE, and developing plugins which handle communications with the simulator, custom project types, built in help where possible, debugging via GDB, logging, and import/export of flight output, e.g. to a Jupyter notebook, or as raw data. The IDE may leverage Eclipse C/C++ and Pydev to provide a unified experience in both languages. Communication between the AI controller and the simulator may be via an asynchronous messaging library, such as ZeroMQ, keeping time synchronized between the simulator and AI code.

Simulator

[0068] FIG. 10A illustrates some aspects of simulator **502** and its operation. FIG. 10 shows simulator **502** coupled to AI controller **508** to simulate a drone (e.g. quadcopter) piloted by AI code on AI controller **508**. Three modules of simulator **502** include the flight controller **1002**, virtual powertrain **1004** (shown in detail in FIG. 10B), and aerodynamic model **1006**. AI code running on AI controller **508** generates input signals **1008**, including commands, which may be the same as commands used for remote-control of a drone. For example, the same command set may be used (e.g. MAVLink, or MAVLink-like commands). Commands may include four axis signals (thrust, yaw, pitch, and roll) in UDP format.

[0069] Input signals **1008** are sent to flight controller **1002**, which may use the same flight controller code used in an actual drone (e.g. may use the same code as flight controller **211**). Flight controller **1002** includes a PID loop module **1010** that receives input signals **1008** from AI controller **508** and simulated sensor data **1012** from aerodynamic model **1006** (real sensor data would be used in real

drone) and uses rate curves **1014** to calculate outputs to execute the commands received in input signals **1008**. Rate curves **1014** may include separate rate curves for thrust, yaw, pitch, and roll, and may reflect rate of change in degrees per second. PID loop module **1010** determines differences between desired rotational position and current rotational position and differences in a previous cycle and applies PID tune parameters to generate control signals. This may occur separately for pitch, roll, and yaw to generate control signals accordingly. These outputs are sent to motor mixer/balancer **1016**, which generates Electronic Speed Control (ESC) outputs **1018**, corresponding to the four motors of a quadcopter. Where flight controller **1002** is implemented as a flight controller of an actual drone, these outputs control the motors to fly the drone. Where flight controller **1002** is implemented as a flight controller of simulator **502** as shown, ESC outputs are provided to virtual powertrain **1004**. Thus, Flight controller **1002** is configured to perform Proportional Integral Derivative (PID) control of quadcopter motors to generate flight controller output signals corresponding to four simulated quadcopter motors of a simulated quadcopter.

[0070] Virtual powertrain **1004** (powertrain module) receives ESC output **1018** as four input signals corresponding to four quadcopter motors, with each input signal handled independently on each frame of simulation. Virtual powertrain **1004** calculates torque and thrust from ESC output **1018** according to characterization data of drone components (described in more detail below). Precise characterization of hardware components allows virtual powertrain **1004** to closely model real hardware (i.e. powertrain of an actual quadcopter) and to accurately calculate torque and thrust values that are generated in a real drone over a range of conditions including dynamic conditions (e.g. accounting for drone orientation and velocity in any thrust calculation). Signals **1020** representing torque (e.g. in Newton-meters “Nm”) and thrust (e.g. in Newtons) are sent from virtual powertrain **1004** to aerodynamic model **1006**. Virtual powertrain **1004** is configured to generate thrust and torque values for the four simulated quadcopter motors from the flight controller output signals **1018** using a plurality of lookup tables with entries indicating quadcopter component characteristics in an accurate manner.

[0071] Aerodynamic model **1006** (aerodynamic module) is based on a calculation of a center of mass of a drone by adding up individual weight contributions of drone components and their distribution. Simulated thrust for each individual motor (e.g. each of four motors of a quadcopter) is applied at the motor attachment point **1022** (i.e. away from the center of mass of the drone). Depending on the balance of individual thrust contributions, combined thrust may generate some rotational forces (e.g. pitch and roll) about the center of mass of the drone. Accordingly, torque for each motor is applied about the center of gravity **1024**. These calculations are used to calculate resulting combined force and angular momentum **1026** produced on the drone. If there is a hard surface below the drone that is substantially parallel to the plane of the propellers, then the resulting thrust is amplified according to the inverse square of the distance to that surface producing “ground effect.” Force and angular momentum are corrected for ground effect by ground effect correction **1028**, which may be in the form of a lookup table based on simulated height (e.g. output of a simulated altimeter or other height sensor). Gravity effects **1030** are also

applied and a drag model **1032** is applied to account for drag forces for different drone surfaces (e.g. top, sides) based on different drag coefficients for different surfaces. Drag model **1032** may result in both drag forces (opposite to the direction of drone movement) and lift forces (perpendicular to the direction of drone movement) depending on drone orientation. Drag and lift forces may be applied at the center of mass according to drag factors based on drone surface area and average drag coefficients. Aerodynamic module **1006** is coupled to receive the thrust and torque values **1020** from the virtual powertrain **1004**, the combine the thrust and torque values for the four simulated quadcopter motors and apply additional factors (e.g. ground effect from proximity of ground below, gravity, lift and drag from movement through air) to obtain velocity, angular velocity, and resulting position/rotation **1036** of the simulated quadcopter, and to provide simulated sensor data **1012** according to the velocity, angular velocity, and position to the flight controller **1002**.

[**0072**] Combined force (thrust) for all motors applied at the center of mass, compensated for ground effect, gravity, drag, lift, and any other significant factors, is used to calculate change in drone velocity (change from prior drone velocity), while combined torque for all motors is used to calculate change in angular velocity. Thus, velocity and angular velocity are calculated and from these values the updated position and rotational position (angular orientation) may be calculated. Velocity, angular velocity and resulting position/rotation **1036** may be used by sensor simulator **1037** to generate simulated sensor data **1012**, which is fed back to flight controller **1002**. This feedback may be provided at a suitable frame rate or frequency (e.g. 60Hz). Sensor simulator **1037** may simulate output from simulated sensors corresponding to drone sensors such as IMU sensors (e.g. including gyroscope and/or accelerometer components).

[**0073**] In addition to providing simulated sensor data **1012** back to flight controller **1002**, for use by PID loop **1010**, velocity, angular velocity and resulting position/rotation **1036** may be used by camera view simulator **1038** (camera simulator) to generate simulated camera view renderings. For example, a simulated environment may include simulated ground, walls, gates, drones, and/or other stationary and/or moving objects that are then simulated in camera renderings according to the position/rotation of the simulated drone. In one example, camera view simulator **1038** generates six simulated camera views that are paired to form three simulated stereoscopic camera views that cover different areas of a simulated environment around a simulated drone. Camera view renderings, along with raw simulated sensor data are provided to AI controller **508**, which may then select a pathway for the drone based on the simulated camera views and simulated sensor data. Thus, AI controller **508** “sees” the simulated environment around the simulated drone and receives additional simulated sensor data and can pilot the simulated drone accordingly by generating commands to control the simulated drone (input signals **1008**).

[**0074**] FIG. 10B shows an example implementation of virtual powertrain **1004** that provides accurate drone simulation based on bench testing of hardware to accurately characterize drone components. While human pilots using drone using a drone simulator may compensate for inaccuracy in simulator output, an AI pilot may be more sensitive in some cases and accurate simulation may be beneficial. For

example, using a simple equation to model behavior of a component may fail to account for some real effects (e.g. turbulence affecting propeller efficiency). Where a simulator is used to train an AI controller (e.g. providing a training set for machine learning) inaccuracy in simulator output may result in an AI controller that is not well adapted for flying a real drone. According to an example presented here, accurate characterization of hardware components is performed and used to generate lookup tables that are quick and easy to access and can be incorporated into a simulator.

[**0075**] FIG. 10B illustrates handling of a single ESC input, corresponding to a single motor, used to generate torque and thrust by virtual powertrain **1004**. It will be understood that each such ESC input is separately handled in a similar manner in virtual powertrain **1004** with the resulting torque and thrust components combined in Aerodynamic model **1006**. ESC output **1018** from flight controller **1002** provides an ESC input to a current lookup table, current LUT **1042**. Current LUT **1042** relates ESC inputs with electrical current based on bench testing of a motor. For example, current LUT **1042** may include a number of entries reflecting average current generated in response to a given ESC input during testing of a significant number of motors (e.g. in excess of 20) over their operational range (e.g. collecting data at 10, 20, or more data points spanning the current range of a motor). Thus, output **1044** of Current LUT **1042** is a current (e.g. expressed in Amps) obtained from an entry corresponding to the ESC input to provide current for different command inputs. Output **1044** is provided to a power lookup table-Power LUT **1046**. Power LUT **1046** is a lookup table that relates current with power (e.g. from Amps to Watts) based on bench testing of a significant number of motors over their operational range (e.g. from zero Amps to a maximum current). Output **1048** of power LUT **1046** is a power (e.g. in Watts), which is provided to Battery adjustment unit **1050**. Battery adjustment unit **1050** uses data related to battery condition (e.g. due to internal resistance, charge level, and/or other factors) as a function of power and may reflect a reduction in power due to such factors so that output **1052** may be a reduced power to account for such effects. Battery adjustment unit **1050** may include one or more lookup table obtained from bench testing of a significant number of batteries over their operational range and under different conditions (e.g. different output currents, different levels of charge, etc.) Output **1052** is provided to Torque LUT **1054** and RPM LUT **1056**. Torque LUT **1054** includes entries providing motor torque at different power so that torque output **1058** is a torque value corresponding to a torque generated in a motor of a drone. RPM LUT **1056** is a lookup table that includes entries providing Revolutions Per Minute (RPM) of a motor at different power so that output **1060** is an RPM estimate. Both Torque LUT and RPM LUT may be based on testing of a significant number of motors across their operational range e.g. from zero RPM to a maximum RPM, from zero torque to a maximum torque. Output **1060** is provided to Delay LUT **1062**, which includes entries that reflect delay in increasing RPMs under different conditions (e.g. different starting RPM) found from bench testing. Delay LUT **1062** applies the corresponding delay or delays to provide output **1064**, which changes RPM compared at an appropriate rate to reflect actual motor response. Output **1064** is sent to RPM reduction unit **1066**, which calculates propeller rotation speed limits based on propeller tip speed and propeller drag from current RPM and drone

speed and reduces RPM accordingly. Thus, output **1068** of RPM reduction unit **1066** may be a reduced RPM compared with output **1064** under some conditions. This may combine propeller speed (in RPM) with drone velocity to dynamically adjust maximum RPM. Output **1068** is provided to Thrust LUT **1070** and Propeller LUT **1072**. Thrust LUT contains entries relating motor static thrust to motor RPM based bench testing of a significant number of motors. Thus, Thrust LUT **1070** generates output **1074**, which is a static thrust value. Propeller LUT **1072** contains entries relating propeller efficiency and RPM based on bench testing a significant number of propellers and may reflect effects such as turbulence that may not be accounted for in a simple propeller model. Thus, Propeller LUT **1072** generates output **1076**, which is a propeller efficiency. Outputs **1074** and **1076** are provided to dynamic thrust unit **1078**, which calculates dynamic thrust values from combining static thrust and propeller efficiency to generate dynamic thrust output **1080** accordingly. Dynamic thrust output **1080** from dynamic thrust unit **1078** and torque output **1058** from Torque LUT **1054** are then sent to aerodynamic model **1006** as combined output **1020** as previously shown.

[0076] FIG. 10C shows steps performed by virtual powertrain **1004** to accurately convert an ESC input to dynamic thrust and torque outputs using lookup tables. The method shown includes the steps of converting ESC to current **1082** (e.g. using Current LUT **1042**), converting the current to power **1084** (e.g. using Power LUT **1046**), and adjusting for battery characteristics **1086** (e.g. using Battery adjustment unit **1050**) to give an accurate power corresponding to the ESC signal received. This method further includes converting this power to RPM **1088** (e.g. using RPM LUT **1056**), delaying RPM **1090** to reflect time for motor RPM to change (e.g. using Delay LUT **1062**), and reducing RPM **1092** according to an RPM limit based on dynamic factors as needed (e.g. according to drone velocity). The delayed (and reduced, if needed) RPM is then used for obtaining static thrust **1094** (e.g. from Thrust LUT **1070**) and obtaining propeller efficiency **1096** (e.g. from Propeller LUT **1072**), which are then used for calculating dynamic thrust **1098**. Calculated dynamic thrust is then provided as output to the aerodynamics simulator. Power, after adjusting for battery characteristics **1086**, is also converted to torque **1099** and the torque value is provided to the aerodynamics simulator.

[0077] FIG. 11 illustrates a method of quadcopter simulation that includes generating and using lookup tables. In particular, FIG. 11 shows a method of quadcopter simulation that includes testing a plurality of quadcopter components (e.g. quadcopter motors, quadcopter propellers, or quadcopter batteries) at a plurality of operating conditions across their operating ranges (e.g. testing quadcopter motors from zero revolutions per minute to a maximum number of revolutions per minute) to obtain test data **1100**, generating one or more lookup tables for characteristics of the plurality of quadcopter components at the plurality of operating conditions from the test data **1102**, and storing the one or more lookup tables for quadcopter component simulation **1104**. The method further includes, subsequently, in a quadcopter simulator, in response to input from a flight controller, receiving a simulated input value for a simulated quadcopter component **1106**, reading one or more entries corresponding to the simulated input value from the one or more lookup tables **1108**, generating a simulated quadcopter component output from the one or more entries **1110**, and generating a

simulated quadcopter output to the flight controller according to the simulated quadcopter component output from the one or more entries **1112**. Testing may include sending commands to quadcopter motors to rapidly change a number of Revolutions Per Minute (RPM), recording observed delay in actual change in RPM, generating the one or more lookup tables may include generating a delay lookup table from the observed delay.

[0078] In order to have accurate lookup tables for virtual powertrain **1004**, a significant number of drone components may be tested over a range of conditions. FIG. 12 illustrates test bench data collection to characterize components of a quadcopter (e.g. steps **1100** and **1102** of FIG. 11) that includes a quadcopter motor **1200** coupled to a propeller **1202** so that the quadcopter motor **1200** can spin the propeller **1202** under static conditions. A power source **1204** (e.g. battery with power controller) is coupled to quadcopter motor **1200** to provide electrical current in a controlled manner. A PC **1206** is connected to quadcopter motor **1200** and may be coupled to power source **1204** (e.g. to control power source **1204** to deliver a controlled current). PC **1206** may be coupled to sensors in or near quadcopter motor **1200** to monitor characteristics of quadcopter motor **1200** while it spins propeller **1202**. For example, PC **1206** may record RPM values for quadcopter motor **1200** with different current provided by power source **1204**. PC **1206** may record power values for different current provided. PC **1206** may record delay in change in RPM for quadcopter motor **1200** after a changed RPM setpoint is provided (e.g. providing a step function in requested RPM and measuring how long it takes actual RPM to reach the new set point). Such data may be gathered over the entire operating range of motor **1200** (e.g. from zero RPM to a maximum RPM), for example, at ten or more points between. Testing may be repeated for a statistically significant number of quadcopter motors and the results may be combined to generate lookup tables (e.g. by averaging). Similarly, a statistically significant number of propellers may be tested, and a statistically significant number of batteries may be tested, and associated lookup tables may be based on combining the test results. Batteries may be tested at different levels of charge, different current outputs, etc. Propellers may be tested at different RPM, proximity to ground (or similar surface). The apparatus shown in FIG. 12 may be used to generate lookup tables of a virtual powertrain (e.g. lookup tables **1042**, **1046**, **1054**, **1056**, **1062**, **1070**, **1072** of virtual powertrain **1004** of FIG. 10B and any other such lookup tables).

[0079] In general, a drone simulator (e.g. a quadcopter simulator) may provide outputs to a pilot (human pilot or an AI controller configured with AI piloting code) that are somewhat different from corresponding output from an actual drone. For example, real sensors and cameras may provide outputs that include some noise. The absence of noise may not be noticeable to a human pilot, or a human pilot may easily compensate for any noise effects. This may not be the case for an AI controller. In order to more accurately simulate sensor and camera output, simulated sensor noise may be added to simulated sensor outputs and simulated camera noise may be added to simulated camera outputs. While such noise may be produced by a random number generator in some cases, noise that more accurately reflects real sensor/camera noise may be obtained from test bench testing of actual components (e.g. under static conditions where the noise may be easily isolated). Statistically

significant populations of components may be tested to obtain noise recordings that are then combined (e.g. averaged) to obtain simulated noise, which may be added to simulated outputs prior to sending such outputs from a simulator to an AI controller.

[0080] FIG. 13 shows an example of a method of quadcopter simulation (e.g. in simulator 502) that includes recording camera output for one or more video cameras under constant conditions 1300 (e.g. with camera lens covered), subtracting a constant signal from the recorded camera output to obtain a camera noise recording 1302, and generating a simulated camera noise from the camera noise recording 1304. Camera noise recordings from bench testing of a statistically significant number of cameras (e.g. more than ten) may be combined to generate the simulated camera noise from combined camera noise recordings from multiple cameras. The method also includes adding the simulated camera noise to a plurality of simulated camera outputs of a quadcopter simulator to generate a plurality of noise-added simulated camera outputs 1306, and sending the plurality of noise-added simulated camera outputs to an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to the quadcopter simulator for the AI controller to use to pilot a simulated quadcopter of the quadcopter simulator 1308. For example, camera view simulator 1038 of FIG. 10A may add simulated camera noise to initial simulated camera outputs before sending the noise-added simulated camera outputs to AI controller 508.

[0081] FIG. 14 shows an example of a method of quadcopter simulation (e.g. in simulator 502), which may be used in combination with the method of FIG. 13, or separately. The method includes recording sensor output for one or more sensors under constant conditions 1400, subtracting a constant signal from the recorded sensor output to obtain a sensor noise recording 1402, generating a simulated sensor noise from the sensor noise recording 1404. Sensor noise recordings from bench testing of a statistically significant number of sensors (e.g. more than ten) over different conditions may be combined to generate the simulated sensor noise. The method also includes adding the simulated sensor noise to a simulated sensor output of a quadcopter simulator to generate a noise-added simulated sensor output 1406 and sending the noise-added simulated sensor output to an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to the quadcopter simulator for the AI controller to use to pilot the quadcopter simulator 1408. For example, sensor simulator 1037 of FIG. 10A may add simulated sensor noise to initial simulated sensor outputs before sending the noise-added simulated sensor outputs to AI controller 508.

[0082] FIG. 15 shows an example of an arrangement for performing the recording of step 1400 of FIG. 14. A PC 1500 with suitable recording capability is coupled to receive outputs from a camera 1502 and a sensor 1504. PC 1500 may record outputs while camera 1502 and sensor 1504 are in conditions to provide constant output. For example, camera 1502 may have its lens covered (for constant zero light conditions) or may be pointed to an unchanging image. Sensor 1504 may be a gyroscope (e.g. in an IMU) and may be spun at a constant speed (e.g. constant angular velocity around an axis) or may be an accelerometer that is at constant acceleration (e.g. stationary), or a rangefinder that is maintained a constant distance from an object or surface. A constant signal may be subtracted from recorded outputs to obtain camera and sensor noise for multiple cameras (e.g. ten or more cameras) and sensors (e.g. ten or more sensors)

and these may then be used to generate simulated camera noise and simulated sensor noise to be added to simulated outputs of a simulator. Camera lens distortion, sensor error, and/or other effects may also be recorded during bench testing and may be incorporated into a simulated sensor and camera outputs.

[0083] Debugging

[0084] In order to ensure that AI code including participant code (e.g. participant code 520 operating in AI controller 508 of FIG. 5) is functional prior to deployment, debugging may be performed while AI code operates to pilot a simulated drone. For example, as shown in FIG. 6A, AI controller 508, running AI code, may be coupled to workstation 628 that includes simulator 502 and debugger 629. FIG. 16 provides an example implementation of such an arrangement that is suitable for debugging and that may be supported by an IDE (e.g. as debugging features 996 of general IDE features 986 illustrated in FIG. 9). Workstation 628 includes simulator 502 and debugger 629, which may be GNU Debugger (GDB). Debugger 629 allows insertion of breakpoints in AI piloting code (e.g. participant code 520) so that AI code stops at predetermined locations. Debugger 629 can then generate a list of AI code variable values of the AI piloting code at the breakpoint. Workstation 628 is coupled to AI controller 508 running participant code 520 (and other code for piloting a simulated drone). AI controller also includes gdbserver 1600, a program in AI controller 508 that works in conjunction with debugger 629 to debug participant code 520. Debugging-related communication between debugger 629 and gdbserver 1600 may be through an Ethernet connection between workstation 628 and AI controller 508 and may use a private IP address range. In this arrangement, simulator 502 is a quadcopter simulator configured to receive quadcopter flight control commands and to generate simulated sensor output and simulated camera output for a plurality of stereoscopic cameras of a simulated quadcopter, the quadcopter simulator implemented workstation 628. AI controller 508 is coupled to the workstation 628, the AI controller configured to receive the simulated sensor output and the simulated camera output for the plurality of stereoscopic cameras from the quadcopter simulator 502, determine a flightpath for the simulated quadcopter according to the simulated sensor output and the simulated camera output, generate the quadcopter flight control commands according to the flightpath, and provide the quadcopter flight control commands to the quadcopter simulator 502. Debugger 629 is implemented in the workstation 628, the debugger is coupled to the simulator 502 and the AI controller 508. The debugger 629 is coupled to perform debugging of AI code of the AI controller 508 (e.g. participant code 520) while the AI controller 508 generates the quadcopter flight control commands for the simulator 502.

[0085] AI controller 508 includes a first clock 1602 while workstation 1604 includes a second clock 1604. These clocks may be synchronized to a high level of accuracy to facilitate debugging. In particular, when an error occurs in participant code 520 it may stop while simulator 502 continues. Accurate synchronization allows simulator 502 to be rewound to a state corresponding to the error, or to an earlier state, so that operations leading up to and including the error in simulator 502 and participant code 520 can be examined. Simulator operations (e.g. quadcopter simulator operations) may be recorded (logged) so to facilitate stepping through operations to identify errors in participant code 520. A high

degree of accuracy may be achieved using Precision Time Protocol (PTP), e.g. as detailed in IEEE 1588. Using PTP hardware timestamping may allow synchronization accuracy of less than 1 millisecond. Communication between simulator **502**, debugger **629**, gdbserver **1600** and participant code **520** may be PTP hardware timestamped so that the last communication from participant code **520** prior to a failure can be used to identify the timing of the failure with a high degree of accuracy and corresponding operations of simulator **502** may be found.

[0086] FIG. 17 illustrates an example of a method of debugging quadcopter piloting code that may be implemented using hardware illustrated in FIG. 16. The method includes coupling an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller configured with AI piloting code to a workstation having a quadcopter simulator **1700** (e.g. coupling AI controller **508** to workstation **628** in FIG. 16), initiating piloting of a simulated quadcopter of the quadcopter simulator by the AI piloting code of the AI controller **1702**, logging operations of the quadcopter simulator during the piloting of the simulated quadcopter **1704**, and timestamping communication between the AI piloting code and the quadcopter simulator **1706**. The method includes, subsequently, in response to an AI piloting code event at an event time, determining the event time from a timestamped communication **1708**, finding a logged operation of the quadcopter simulator having a timestamp corresponding to the event time **1710**, rewinding the quadcopter simulator to at least the logged operation **1712**; and stepping through one or more operations of the quadcopter simulator and the AI piloting code to identify AI piloting code errors relating to the AI piloting code event **1714**.

[0087] An AI controller may be implemented using various components, with FIG. 18 providing an example of a controller module that includes a System-on-Chip (SOC) **1800** (e.g. NVIDIA Xavier SOC), which may include core CPUs (e.g. 12 Volta core GPUs and 8 core ARM 64 bit CPUs), RAM (e.g. 16 GB LPDDR4 memory) and additional components. This may be considered an implementation of AI controller **506** of FIG. 6A and is similarly shown coupled to workstation **628**. HDMI to MIPI converter **634** converts simulated camera output from workstation **628** to MIPI format for AI controller **508**. AI controller **508** includes a fan **1804** and fan driver **1802** to provide cooling as required (AI controller may be housed in an enclosure and may generate significant heat). A power adaptor **1806** and external power interface **1808** are provided to receive electrical power from an external source (e.g. power supply or battery) and provide it to subsystem power unit **1810**. Subsystem power unit **1810** is also coupled to battery **1812** and battery management unit **1814** and can select a power source to power SOC **1800** and other components (e.g. using battery **1812** when external power is not available).

[0088] In an alternative configuration, AI controller **508** may be coupled to live hardware (e.g. live hardware **510**, shown in FIG. 6A, for live hardware testing). FIG. 19 shows an example in which live hardware **510** includes six video cameras **1900**, for example, IMX265 MIPI cameras from Leopard Imaging, Inc. Live hardware **510** also includes sensors **1902** including IMUs **1904** and rangefinder **1906**. IMUs **1904** may include two IMUs, for example a Bosch 6 axis BMI088 and an InvSense 6 axis MPU-6050 TDK. Rangefinder **1906** may be a Garmin LIDAR lite V3. The configuration of FIG. 19 may be used for hardware-in-the-

loop testing of AI code of AI controller **508** after testing using a simulator as shown in FIG. 18.

[0089] When AI code is tested (e.g. using simulator and hardware-in-the-loop testing), the AI code may be deployed and used as an AI module of an autonomous drone to pilot the drone without remote-control input. FIG. 20 shows an example of AI controller **508** in an autonomous drone **2000**, which is configured to be piloted by AI controller **508**. Autonomous drone **2000** may be considered an example implementation of drone **301** of FIG. 3. Autonomous drone **2000** includes six video cameras **1900** (e.g. configured as three stereoscopic cameras) and sensors **1902** including IMUs **1904** and rangefinder **1906**. Output **2002** (e.g. SBUS output) from AI controller **508** goes to an RF communications circuit **2004** (control radio module) which is connected to antenna **2006** (which may couple it to a remote unit or remote-control). RF communications circuit **2004** is coupled to flight controller **2008** to send flight control commands to flight controller **2008**. Flight control commands may come from AI controller **508** or from a remote unit (via RF communications) according to the same command format so that commands are interchangeable. Thus, when RF communications circuit **2004** receives a command from a remote unit to take over piloting from AI controller **508**, RF communications circuit **2004** stops sending the commands from AI controller **508** to flight controller **2008** and instead sends commands from the remote unit. Flight controller **2008** includes various modules including a motor controller **2010** module that controls four Electronic Speed Control (ESC) units **2012** that drive four quadcopter motors **2014** (which are coupled to corresponding fixed-pitch propellers—not shown). Hall effect sensors **2016** monitor quadcopter motors **2014** to provide feedback to motor controller **2010**. A transponder controller **2018** controls infrared (IR) emitters **2020** that may be used to monitor a quadcopter as it flies around a racecourse. An LED controller **2022** controls LEDs **2026** (Light Emitting Diodes) through multiplexer **2024** (MUX) which may illuminate autonomous drone **2000**. In addition to sensors **1902** coupled to AI controller **508**, sensors **2028** may be directly connected to flight controller **2008** and may include one or more IMUs and a barometer (e.g. Bosch BMP280). In addition to cameras **1900** coupled to AI controller **508** for computer vision, quadcopter **2000** includes camera **2030**, which may be used to send video to a remote user for remote-control piloting of quadcopter **2000** using first-person view (FPV). Output from camera **2030** is sent to On Screen Display unit **2032** and to video transmitter **2034** for transmission to the remote user via antenna **2036**. A main battery **2040** provides a principal source of power for flight controller **2008** (including motors **2014**) via flight controller subsystem power unit **2042** and, in this example also provides power to battery management unit **1814** of AI controller **508** (e.g. AI controller **508** may be powered from main battery **2040** or from battery **1812**).

[0090] An autonomous quadcopter such as autonomous quadcopter **2000** of FIG. 20 may be operated so that it flies autonomously using an AI module such as AI controller **508** instead of a human pilot using a remote-control. An example of a method of operating a quadcopter is illustrated in FIG. 21 which includes generating a plurality of stereoscopic camera views for a plurality of fields of view around the quadcopter **2100**, providing the plurality of stereoscopic camera views to a hardware abstraction layer **2102** (e.g. HAL **516**), deinterleaving of the plurality of stereoscopic

camera views in the hardware abstraction layer **2104**, providing deinterleaved frames to an Artificial Intelligence (AI) module **2106**, and generating object-location information for objects in the plurality of fields of view from the deinterleaved frames in the AI module **2108**. For example, objects around a drone racecourse may be located and identified using computer vision based on stereoscopic camera views. The method further includes determining in the AI module a flight path for the quadcopter according to the object-location information **2110**, generating a plurality of commands in the AI module corresponding to the flight path **2112**, sending the plurality of commands from the AI module to a flight controller of the quadcopter; **2114**, and controlling a plurality of motors of the quadcopter according to the plurality of commands such that the quadcopter follows the flight path **2116**.

[0091] FIGS. **22A-D** show an example of an implementation of autonomous drone **2000** as shown schematically in FIG. **20**, which may be operated as illustrated in FIG. **21**. FIG. **22A** shows autonomous drone **2000** from the front with AI controller **508** mounted on top of chassis **2202** and with motors **2204**, **2206** and corresponding propellers **2208**, **2210** also mounted on top of chassis **2202**. Motors **2204**, **2206** correspond to two of four motors **2014** of FIG. **20** (the other two motors are not visible in this view. Six cameras are mounted on the bottom of chassis **2202**. Cameras are arranged in pairs to form stereoscopic cameras. Thus, cameras **2212a** and **2212b** form a first stereoscopic camera looking down and forward of autonomous quadcopter **2000**. Cameras **2214a** and **2214b** form a second stereoscopic camera looking forward and to the right of autonomous quadcopter **2000** (to the left in the view of FIG. **22A**). Cameras **2216a** and **2216b** form a third stereoscopic camera looking forward and to the left of autonomous quadcopter **2000** (to the right in the view of FIG. **22A**).

[0092] FIG. **22B** shows a perspective view of autonomous drone **2000** from above and to the left, showing propellers **2208**, **2209**, **2210**, and **2211** mounted to the top of chassis **2202**. AI controller **508** can be seen mounted to the top of chassis **2202**. Cameras **2214b**, **2216a**, and **2216b**, mounted to the bottom of chassis **2202** are also visible in this view.

[0093] FIG. **22C** shows a top-down view of autonomous drone **2000** including propellers **2208**, **2209**, **2210**, **2211** and AI controller **508** mounted on top of chassis **2202**.

[0094] FIG. **22D** shows a bottom-up view of autonomous drone **2000** including cameras **2212a**, **2212b**, **2214a**, **2214b**, **2216a**, **2216b** mounted to the underside of chassis **2202**.

[0095] For purposes of this document, it should be noted that the dimensions of the various features depicted in the figures may not necessarily be drawn to scale.

[0096] For purposes of this document, reference in the specification to “an embodiment,” “one embodiment,” “some embodiments,” or “another embodiment” may be used to describe different embodiments or the same embodiment.

[0097] For purposes of this document, a connection may be a direct connection or an indirect connection (e.g., via one or more other parts). In some cases, when an element is referred to as being connected or coupled to another element, the element may be directly connected to the other element or indirectly connected to the other element via intervening elements. When an element is referred to as being directly connected to another element, then there are no intervening elements between the element and the other

element. Two devices are “in communication” if they are directly or indirectly connected so that they can communicate electronic signals between them.

[0098] For purposes of this document, the term “based on” may be read as “based at least in part on.”

[0099] For purposes of this document, without additional context, use of numerical terms such as a “first” object, a “second” object, and a “third” object may not imply an ordering of objects, but may instead be used for identification purposes to identify different objects.

[0100] For purposes of this document, the term “set” of objects may refer to a “set” of one or more of the objects.

[0101] The foregoing detailed description has been presented for purposes of illustration and description. It is not intended to be exhaustive or to limit to the precise form disclosed. Many modifications and variations are possible in light of the above teaching. The described embodiments were chosen in order to best explain the principles of the proposed technology and its practical application, to thereby enable others skilled in the art to best utilize it in various embodiments and with various modifications as are suited to the particular use contemplated. It is intended that the scope be defined by the claims appended hereto.

1. An autonomous quadcopter comprising:

four motors, each motor coupled to a corresponding propeller;

a flight controller coupled to the four motors to provide input to the four motors to control flight of the autonomous quadcopter;

a plurality of cameras; and

an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to the plurality of cameras to receive input from the plurality of cameras, determine a flightpath for the autonomous quadcopter according to the input from the plurality of cameras, and provide commands to the flight controller to direct the flight controller to follow the flightpath.

2. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 wherein the plurality of cameras includes three pairs of cameras, each pair of cameras configured to obtain a stereoscopic view of a different area around the autonomous quadcopter.

3. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 further comprising:

a Radio Frequency (RF) communication circuit coupled to the flight controller, the RF communication circuit configured to receive external commands from a remote-control and provide the external commands to the flight controller to direct the flight controller to follow a remotely-selected flightpath, the external commands and the commands provided by the AI controller from a common command set.

4. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 3 wherein the autonomous quadcopter is configurable to receive either the external commands from the remote-control or the commands from the AI controller according to selection by a remote-control user.

5. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 wherein the AI controller is connected to the flight controller through a connector, the AI controller is removable from the autonomous quadcopter to reconfigure the autonomous quadcopter as a remote-controlled quadcopter.

6. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 further comprising one or more of: a gyroscopic sensor, accelerometer, a range sensor, coupled to provide input to the AI controller.

7. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 further comprising a hardware abstraction layer configured to separate interleaved camera output received from cameras of the plurality of cameras and to separately buffer deinterleaved output such that frames of an individual camera are separately buffered and available at a predetermined frame rate.

8. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 1 wherein the AI controller includes an AI master, scheduler, and libraries of routines provided by a Software Development Kit (SDK) provider and includes participant code generated by a participant using the SDK.

9. An autonomous quadcopter comprising:

four motors, each motor coupled to a corresponding fixed-pitch propeller;

a flight controller coupled to the four motors to provide input to the four motors to control flight of the autonomous quadcopter;

a Radio Frequency (RF) communication circuit coupled to the flight controller, the RF communication circuit configured to receive external commands from a remote-control and provide the external commands to the flight controller to direct the flight controller to follow a remotely-selected flightpath in a remote-control mode;

a plurality of stereoscopic cameras; and

an Artificial Intelligence (AI) controller coupled to the plurality of stereoscopic cameras to receive input from the plurality of stereoscopic cameras, perform hardware abstraction on the input from the plurality of stereoscopic cameras, analyze abstracted input from the plurality of stereoscopic cameras to determine locations of objects around the autonomous quadcopter, determine a flight path for the autonomous quadcopter according to the locations of the objects, and provide commands to the flight controller to direct the flight controller to follow the flight path in an autonomous mode.

10. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 9 further comprising a connector between the AI controller and the flight controller for configuration of the autonomous quadcopter as autonomous with the AI controller connected or as remote-controlled with the AI controller disconnected from the flight controller.

11. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 9 wherein the plurality of stereoscopic cameras includes three stereoscopic cameras in different orientations with respect to the autonomous quadcopter.

12. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 11 further comprising one or more Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU) sensors coupled to the AI controller to provide autonomous quadcopter motion data to the AI controller.

13. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 12 further comprising a rangefinder coupled to the AI controller, the

rangefinder configured to determine distance between an object and the autonomous quadcopter.

14. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 13 wherein the AI controller includes a hardware abstraction layer configured to receive input from the plurality of stereoscopic cameras, the one or more IMU sensors, and the rangefinder, and to buffer sensor and camera data.

15. The autonomous quadcopter of claim 14 wherein the hardware abstraction layer is further configured to provide output to a plurality of motors of the autonomous quadcopter.

16. A method of operating a quadcopter comprising:

generating a plurality of stereoscopic camera views for a plurality of fields of view around the quadcopter;

providing the plurality of stereoscopic camera views to a hardware abstraction layer;

deinterleaving of the plurality of stereoscopic camera views in the hardware abstraction layer;

providing deinterleaved frames to an Artificial Intelligence (AI) module;

generating object-location information for objects in the plurality of fields of view from the deinterleaved frames in the AI module;

determining in the AI module a flight path for the quadcopter according to the object-location information;

generating a plurality of commands in the AI module corresponding to the flight path;

sending the plurality of commands from the AI module to a flight controller of the quadcopter; and

controlling a plurality of motors of the quadcopter according to the plurality of commands such that the quadcopter follows the flight path.

17. The method of claim 16 wherein the objects in the plurality of fields of view include other quadcopters and racecourse features, and wherein determining the flight path for the quadcopter includes determining the fastest flightpath to complete a racecourse without hitting the other quadcopters or racecourse features.

18. The method of claim 17 wherein determining the flight path for the quadcopter occurs autonomously, without input from a human pilot.

19. The method of claim 17 wherein sending the plurality of commands to the flight controller occurs over an interface that is coupled to a Radio Frequency (RF) receiver to alternatively receive commands from the RF receiver according to a common command set.

20. The method of claim 19 further comprising disabling commands from the AI controller and enabling commands from the RF receiver in response to a command received by the RF receiver from a remote-control.

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